



Fisheries and Oceans
Canada

Pêches et Océans
Canada

An aerial photograph of a coastal area with several small, forested islands and peninsulas. The water is a deep blue, and the land is covered in green trees. A large, semi-transparent blue maple leaf is overlaid on the image, with its center positioned over the text. The text is white and reads "Pacific Herring Tier 2 Post-Season Meeting" in a large, bold font, with "April 30, 2025" in a smaller font below it.

Pacific Herring Tier 2 Post-Season Meeting

April 30, 2025

Agenda

TIME	TOPIC	LEAD
9:00 – 9:15am	Welcome and introductions	B. Rusch, DFO
9:15 – 9:30am	Review of agenda, meeting objectives and action items	B. Rusch, DFO
9:30am – 12:00pm	Strait of Georgia Review	E. Miyagi, DFO
	West Coast Vancouver Island Review	S. Kagan, DFO
	Break	
	Central Coast Review	J. Savickas, DFO
	Prince Rupert District – Big Bay & Kitkatla Review	C. Martens & K. Lord, DFO
	Haida Gwaii Review	P. Fairweather, DFO
12:00 – 12:15pm	Wrap up	B. Rusch, DFO
12:15pm	Meeting adjourned	

Meeting Objectives

- Review previous action items
- Review of 2024/2025 Pacific Herring fisheries
- Provide an update 2025 spring-summer engagement

Action Items – Tier 2

- DFO to consider any changes or other options for the stock assessment program to help facilitate more First Nations involvement and capacity building for stock assessment.
 - DFO used contracts and AFS funding to support First Nations led stock assessment projects where available last season. DFO will continue to seek funding sources for proposed projects in subsequent seasons.
- Investigate options for coastwide survey contract process.
 - DFO will continue to consider best available options for the coast wide program. Preference is to have one coast wide contract which provides flexibility amongst vessels/areas.
- DFO to send an update when Batch 2 stocks are published in Canada Gazette I.
 - Completed action. Notification was sent for comment period from Oct to Nov 2024.

Area Reviews

SOG
(Eamon/Andrea)

WCVI
(Samantha)

CC (Justin &
Amanda)

PRD – Big Bay &
Kitkatla (Corey &
Karlana)

HG (Pat)



Strait of Georgia



Resource Managers:

Gillnet:

Andrea Haas

Seine:

Eamon Miyagi

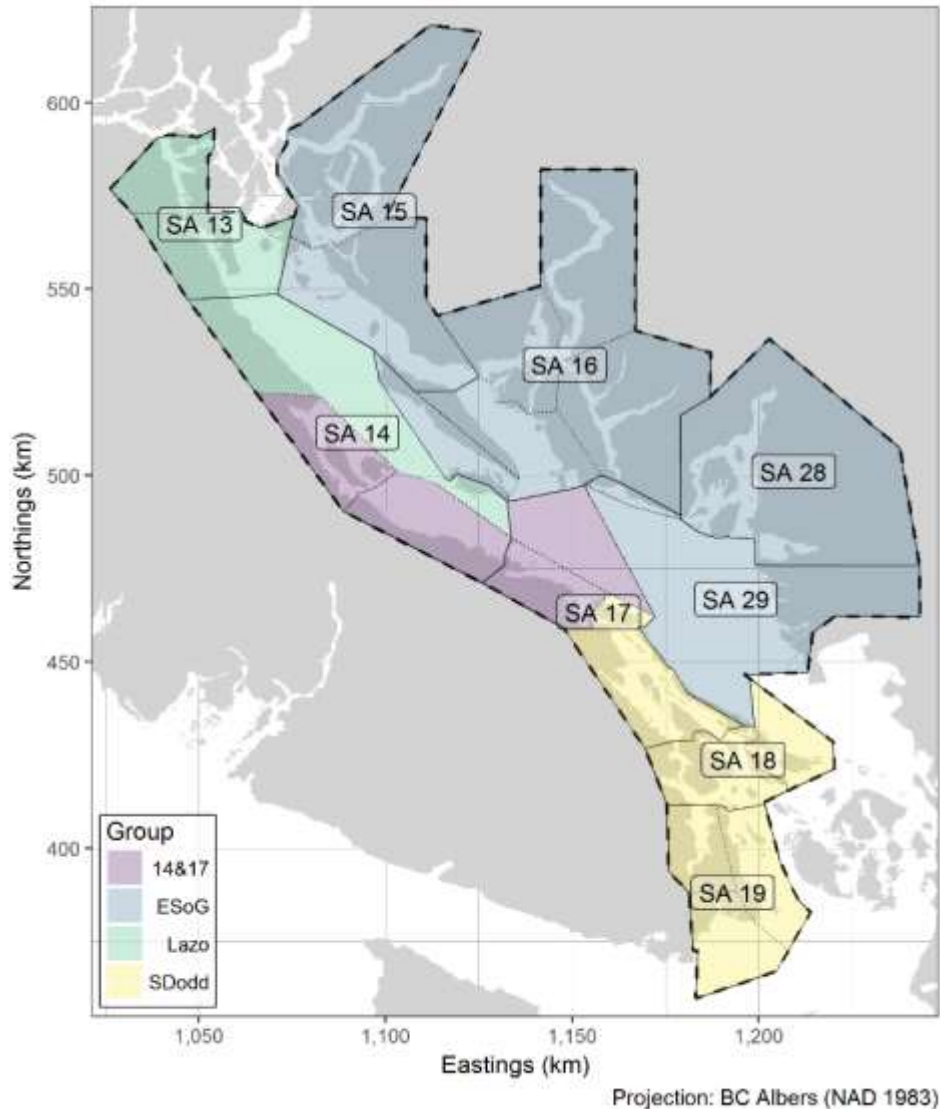
Christie Morrison

Spawn survey coordinator:

Matt Thompson



Stock Assessment Area – SOG



DFO Test Vessel Denman Isle

2025 Stock Assessment Resources

Management Platform	Vessel Master	Dates (# days)
Viking Tide	Tyson Wachsmuth	Feb 27 – Mar 14 (16 days)

DFO Charter Test Vessel

Denman Isle	Barry Curic	Feb 20 – Mar 18 (27 days)
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Industry Funded Test Vessels

Viking Cavalier	Al Marsden	Mar 1-9 (8 days)
Nita Maria	Brian Vogrig	Mar 8,9 (2 days)
Western Investor	Kevin Smith	Mar 10,13 (2 days)
Alaska Queen	Jay Soleway	March 9,13,14 (2 days)

DFO Charter Dive Vessels

Pacific Discovery	Dennis Dobrilla	Mar 14 – Mar 31 (18 days)
Ocean Cloud	Mitch Ponak	Mar 13 – Mar 24 (12 days)

Spawn Flights	Flight Coordinator	Dates (# Flights)
BC Air	Matt Thompson	Mar 3 - Mar 31 (14 flights)

Other Programs

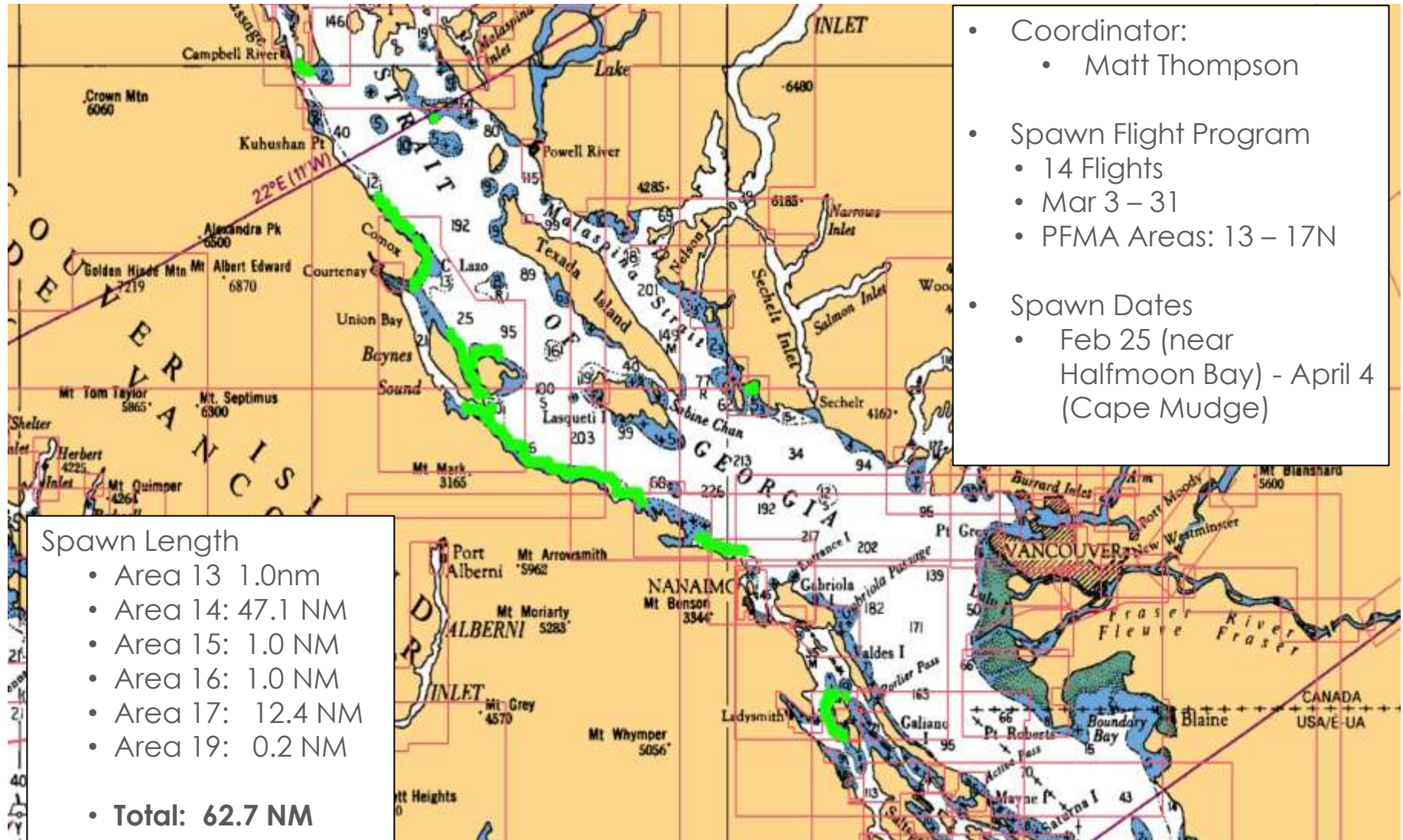
A-Tlegay Assessments	Derek LeBoeuf	Dive/surface surveys and outreach
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Harvest Level Decision Context - SOG

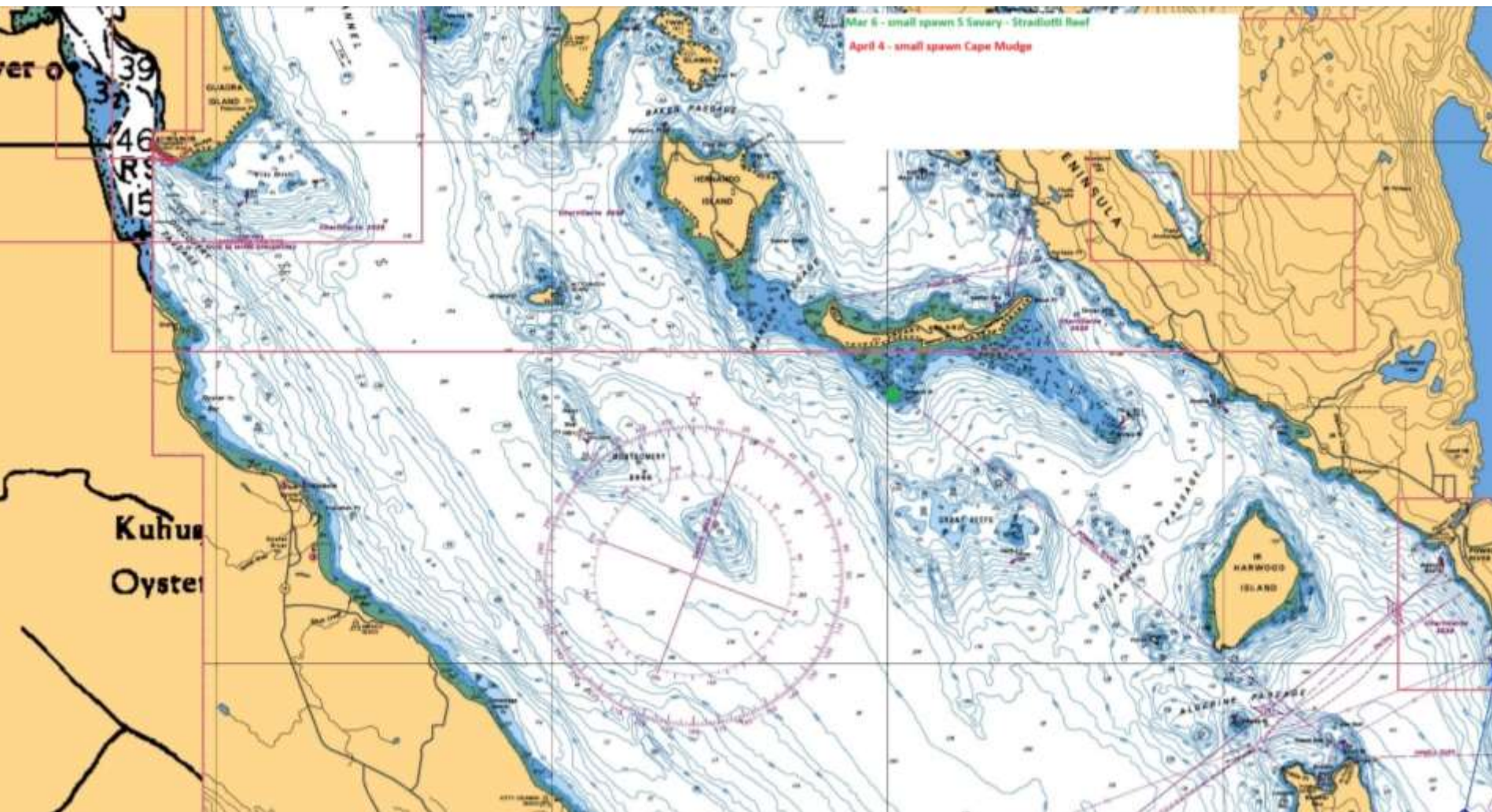
- 2025 spawning biomass forecasted to be 90,900 tons (maximum likelihood forecast).
- A 14% harvest rate to support FSC/Domestic Harvest, Food and Bait, Special Use, and Roe Herring fisheries, to a maximum of 12,787 tons was selected.
 - Note: SOK fisheries do not occur in SOG area



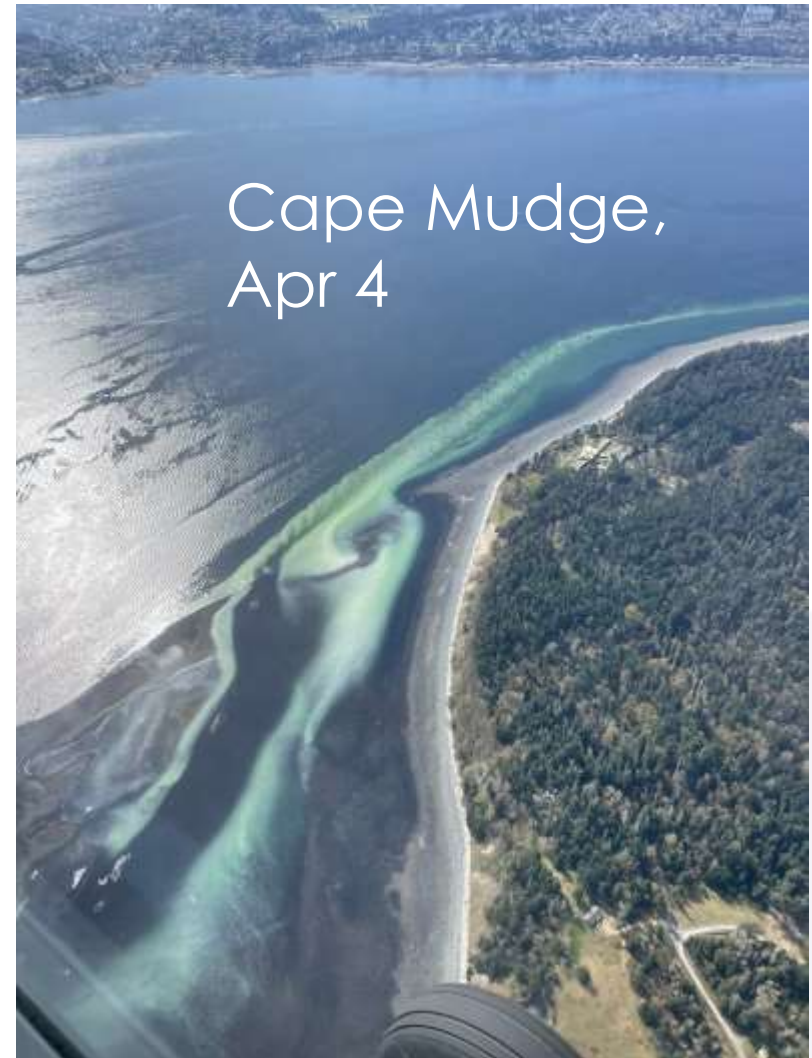
SOG - Spawn Flight Observations



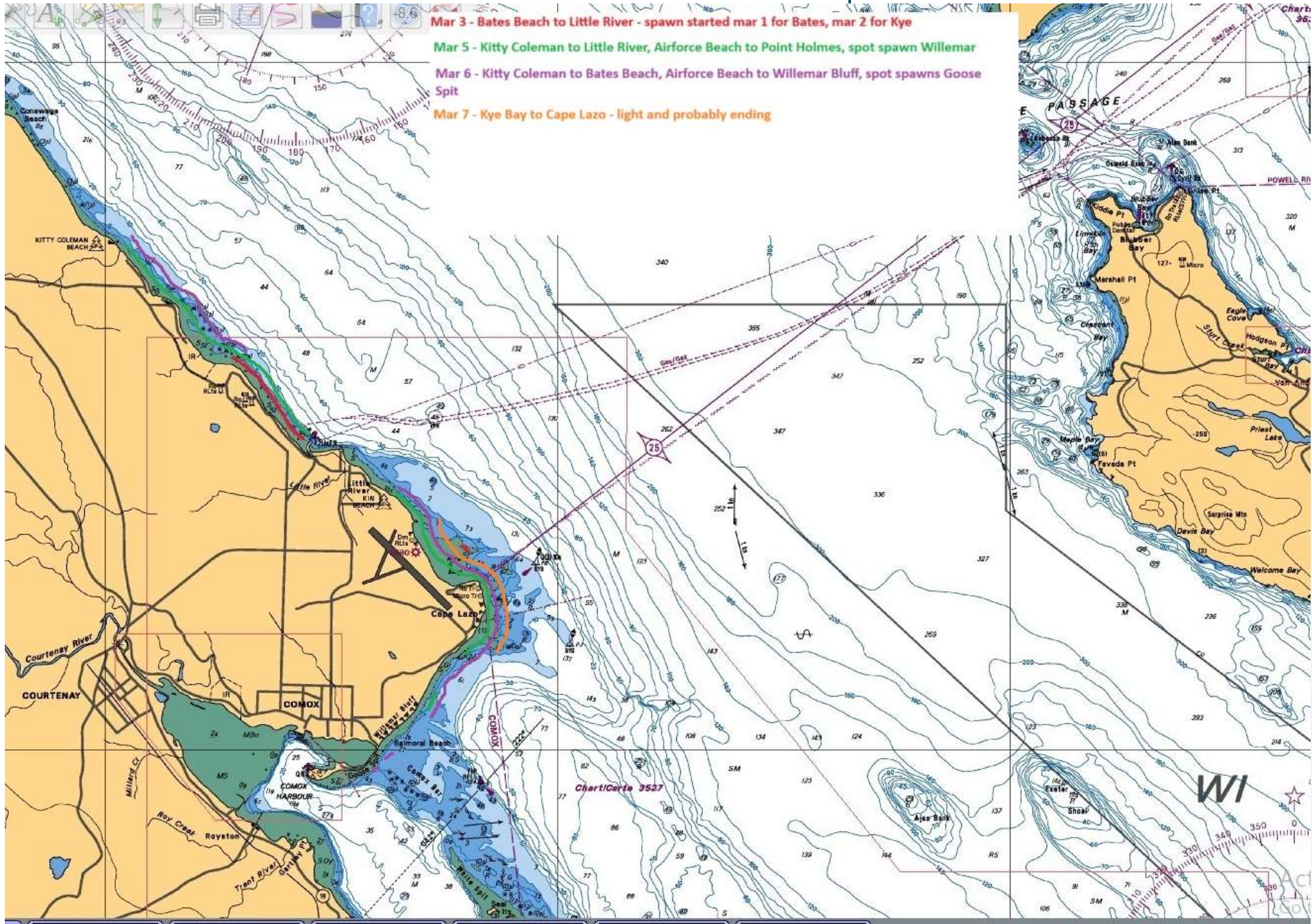
Areas 13, 14, 15 Campbell River to Miracle Beach



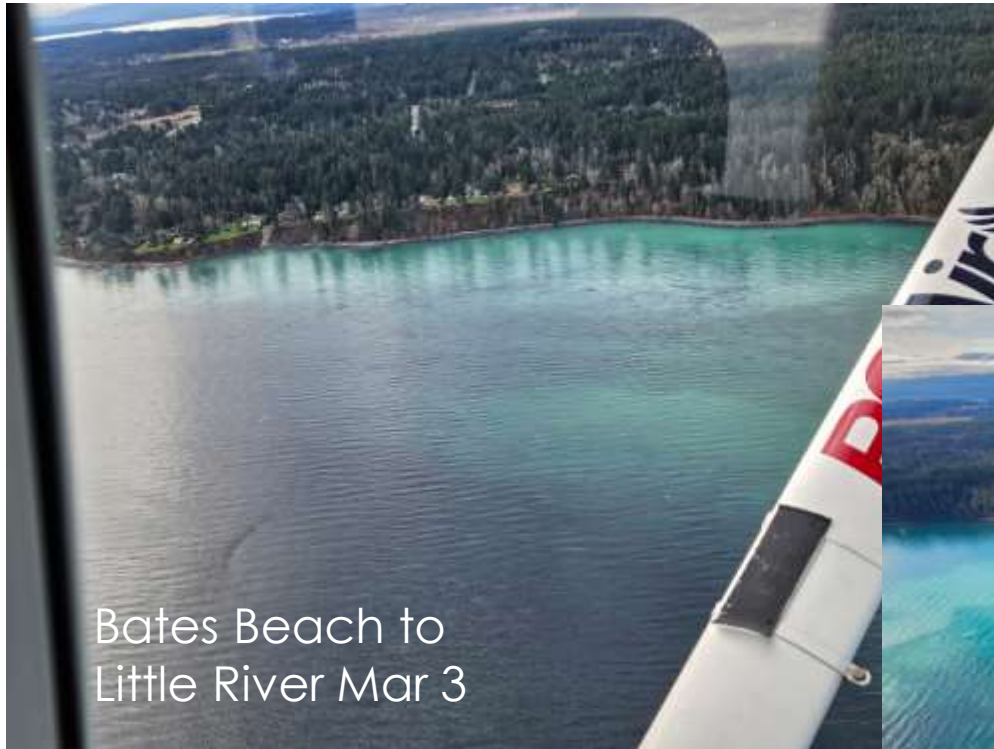
Areas 13, 14, 15
Campbell River to Miracle Beach



Area 14 Miracle Beach to Cape Lazo



Area 14 Miracle Beach to Cape Lazo

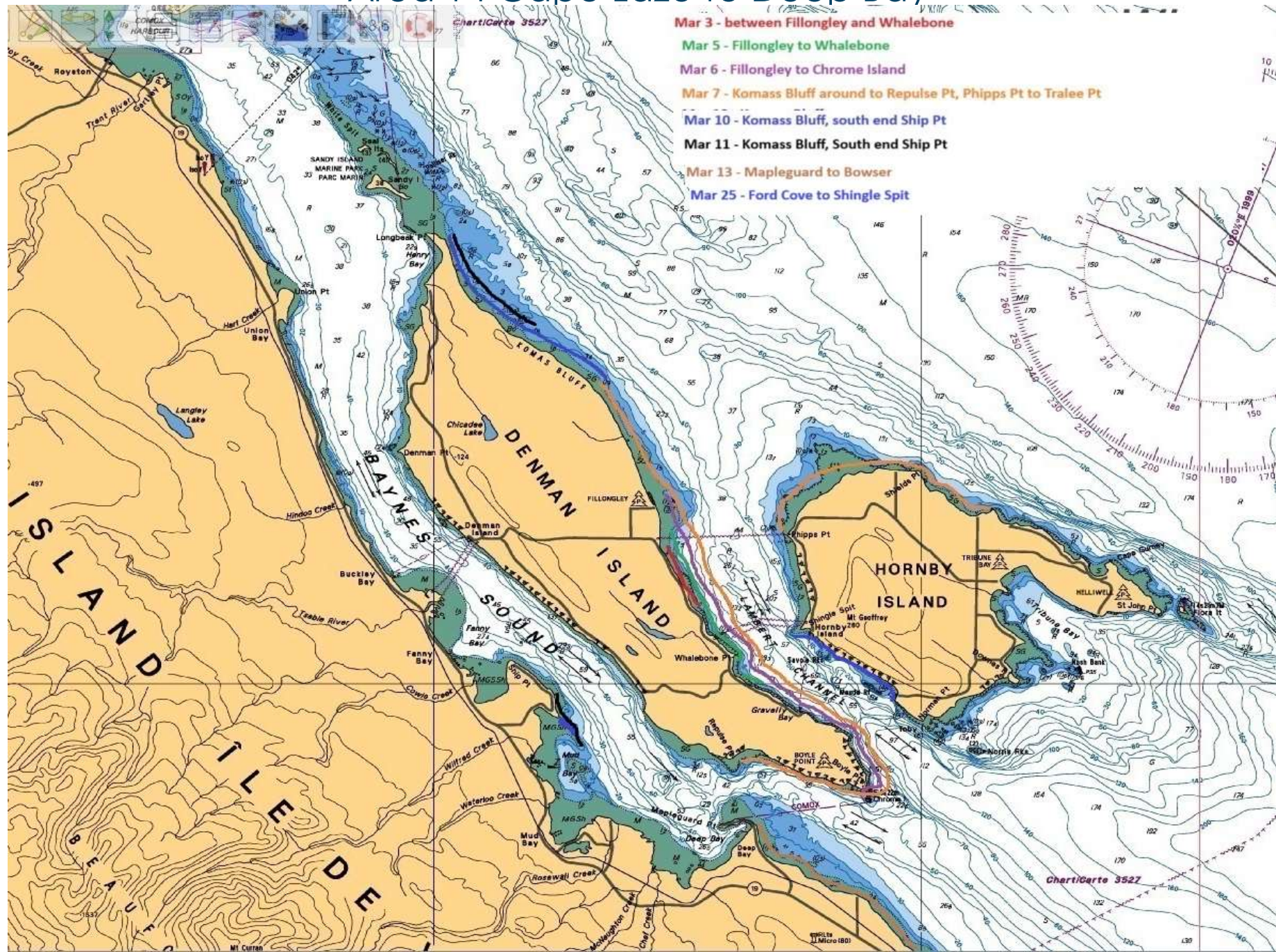


Bates Beach to
Little River Mar 3

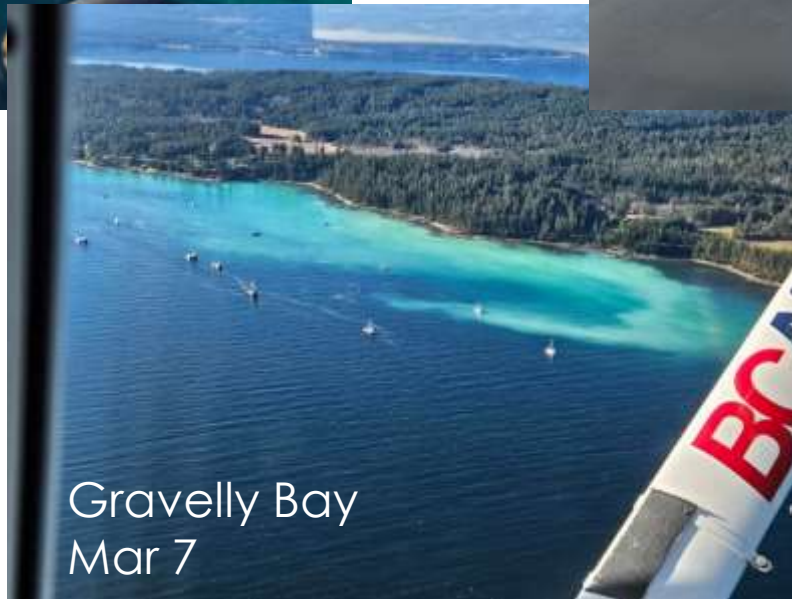


Kitty Coleman to Little
River Mar 5

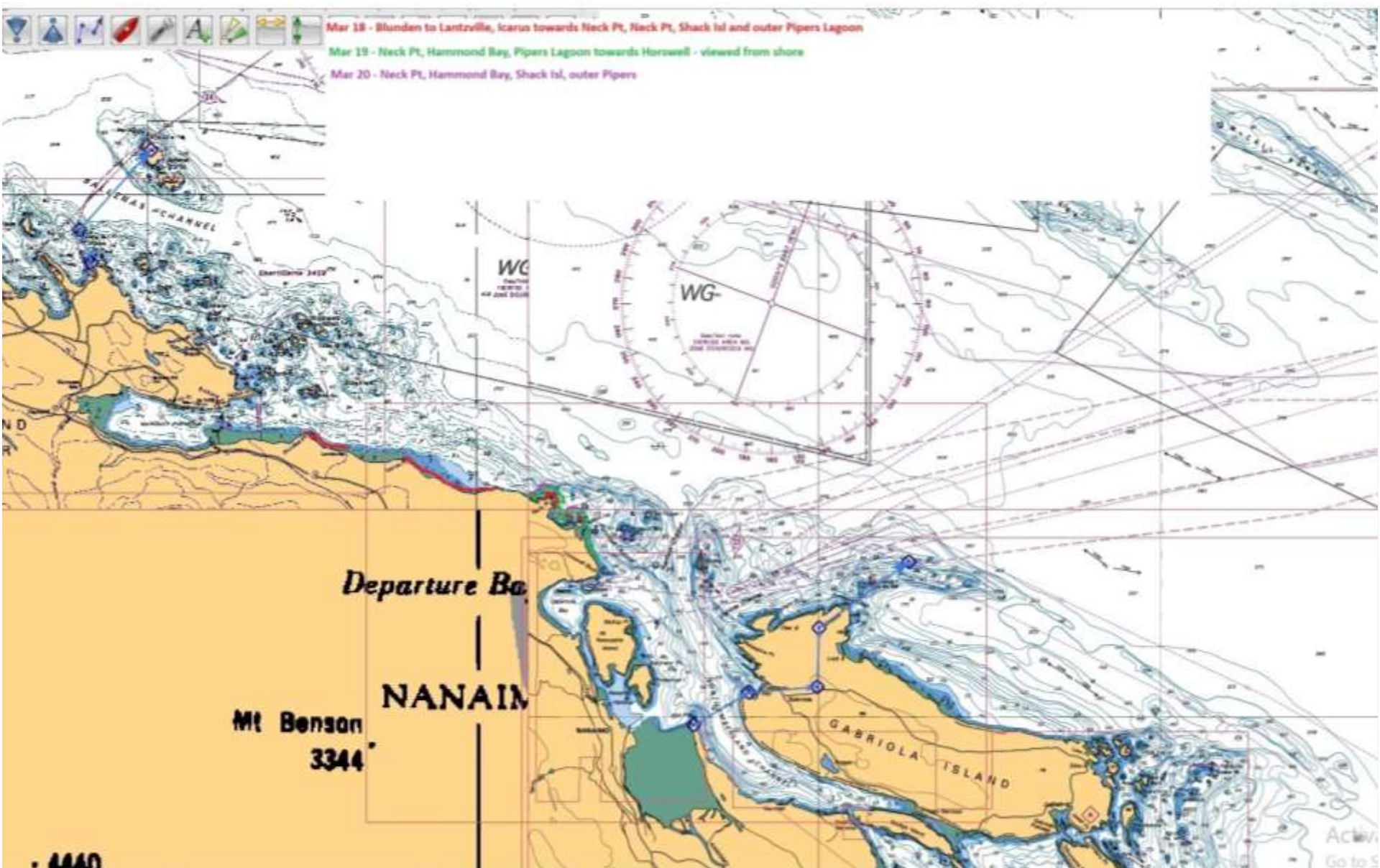
Area 14 Cape Lazo to Deep Bay



Area 14 Cape Lazo to Deep Bay



Area 14 Parksville to Area 17 South



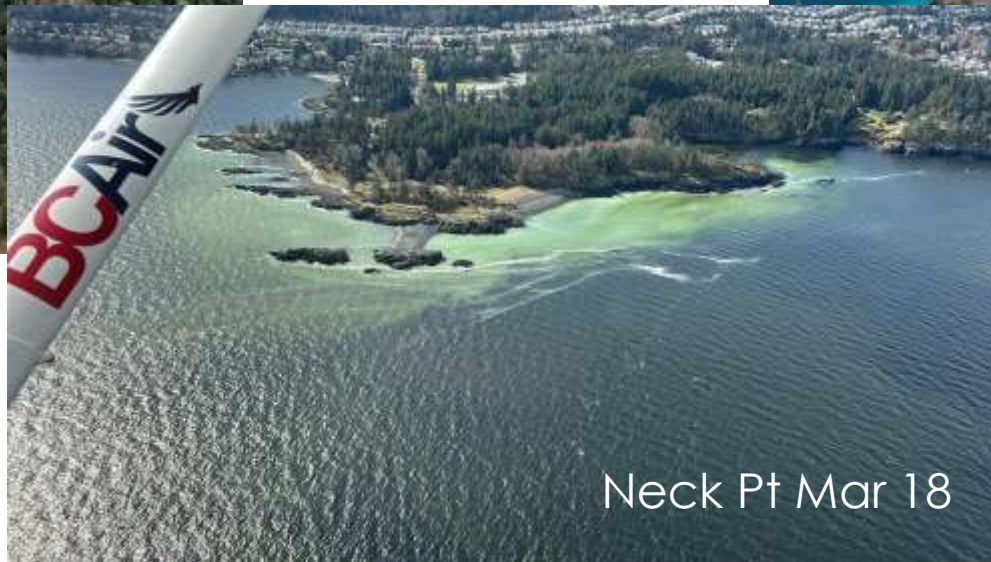
Area 14 Parksville to Area 17 South



Neck Pt Mar 20

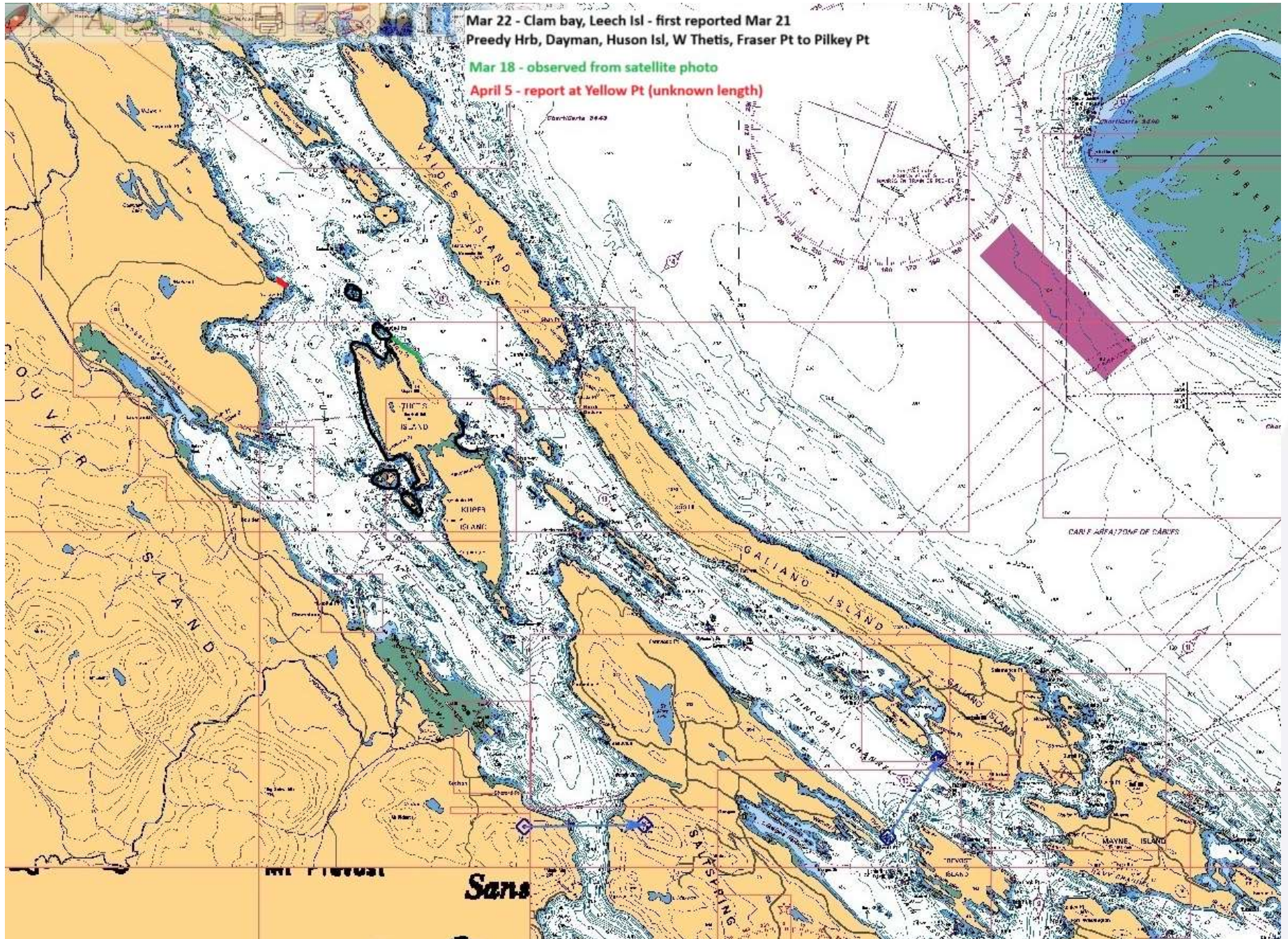


Piper's Lagoon
Mar 20

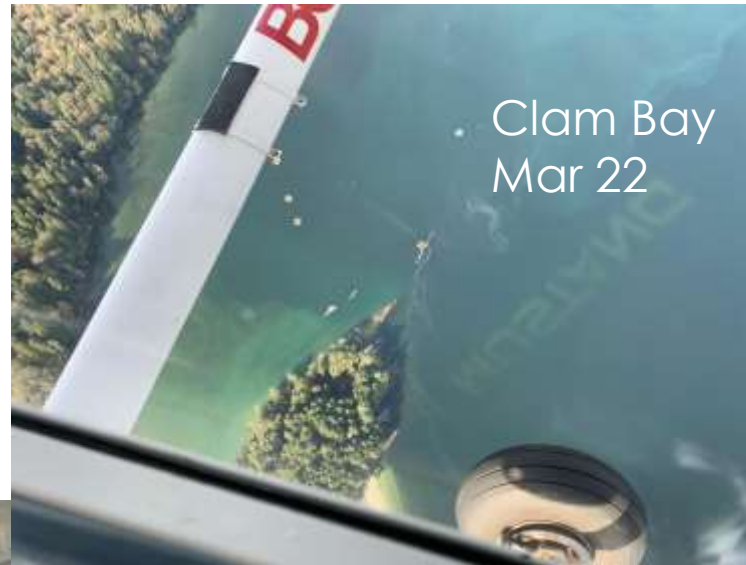


Neck Pt Mar 18

Area 17 South



Area 17 South



Additional Spawn Reports

Area 12 – Beaver Harbour

- Reported: Mar 20
- Dive survey was conducted

Area 13 – Cape Mudge

- Reported: Apr 4

Area 15- Toba Inlet

- Unknown Location and Size

Area 16 – Halfmoon Bay

- Reported: Feb 25

Area 19 – Fisgard light

- Spawning occurred on Mar15
- Small spawn
- 3rd event in 4 years at this location

A-Tlegay Stock Assessment (Area 13/15)

Outreach Program

- Notified of spawn at Cape Mudge on April 4.
- Stradiotti Reef

Dive/Surface survey

Toba Inlet

Savary Island



Bute Inlet Dive Survey | Credit: A-tlegay

Strait of Georgia – Fisheries

- Food & Bait
- Special Use
- Roe Herring-Seine
- Roe Herring-Gillnet

FSC:

- Spawn on Bough
- Whole Herring



SOG Quota & Catch (Short Tons) 2024/25

	Expected Use / Quota	Catch Target	Catch
Food and Bait	2,100	2,025.3 ^a	2,017
FSC	35	35	NA ^b
Special Use	902	696 ^c	623.6
Roe Seine	4,912	4,899.3 ^a	3,002.5
Roe Gillnet	4,837	4,837.0	4,795.0
Total	12,786		10,438

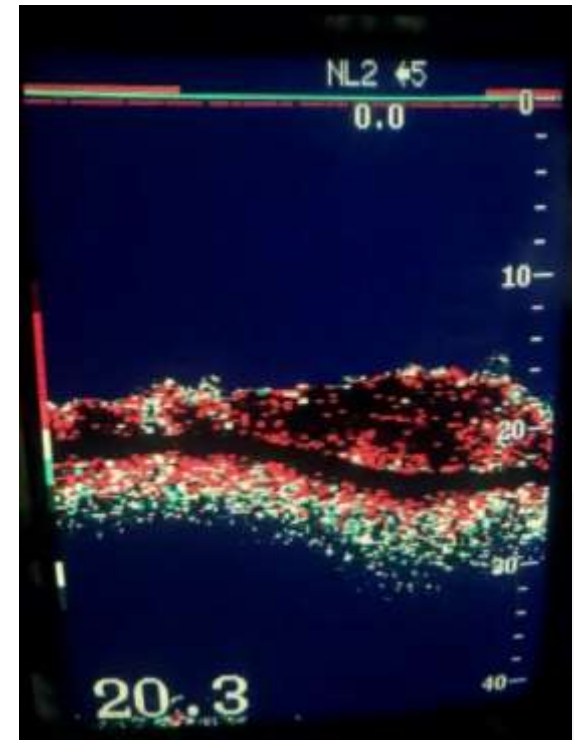
^a Food and Bait-Roe seine licence quota transfers

^b Catch numbers not available.

^c Licences issued to date

SOG Food & Bait Fishery

- Food & Bait fishery opened November 29, 2024 and closed Feb 12, 2025.
- 2,100 ton quota of which 100 tons assigned to a single designated ZM licence to support charities.
- Closures in Area 15, 17S, 18 and Subarea 29-5 (as requested from some First Nations) are maintained for the 2024/25 season.
- New this year – herring seine licence eligibility holders had the option after January 17 (IFMP release) to fish licence shares in either the roe or the food and bait fishery (allocations will be accounted for within the final TAC established for the SOG).
- 2,017 ton catch – 164 ZM licences/32 HS licences



SOG Special Use Fishery

- Special Use fishery opened November 27, 2024.
- Special Use licence categories include - Personal use, sport/commercial bait, human food, zoo and aquarium
- Fishery open in SOG only
 - November 27, 2024 - February 15, 2025 (all quota)
 - May 1, 2025 – October 1, 2025 (≤ 3 ton quota only)
 - October 1, 2025 - November 6, 2025 (reopens to quota ≥ 3 tons)
- Small tonnage (<3 tons) licences are open to any interested party provided that the specific licence requirements and eligibility criteria are met
- 902 ton quota
 - Landings to date: 623.6 tons

SOG Roe Test Fishery - 2025

- **DFO Test Vessel:**
 - Denman Isle (27 Days)
 - Feb 20 – Mar 18
- **DFO Management Platform:**
 - Viking Tide (16 Days)
 - Feb 27 - Mar 14
- **Industry Test Vessels:**
 - Viking Cavalier
 - Nita Maria
 - Western Investor
 - Alaska Queen



Herring Roe, March 1 2025

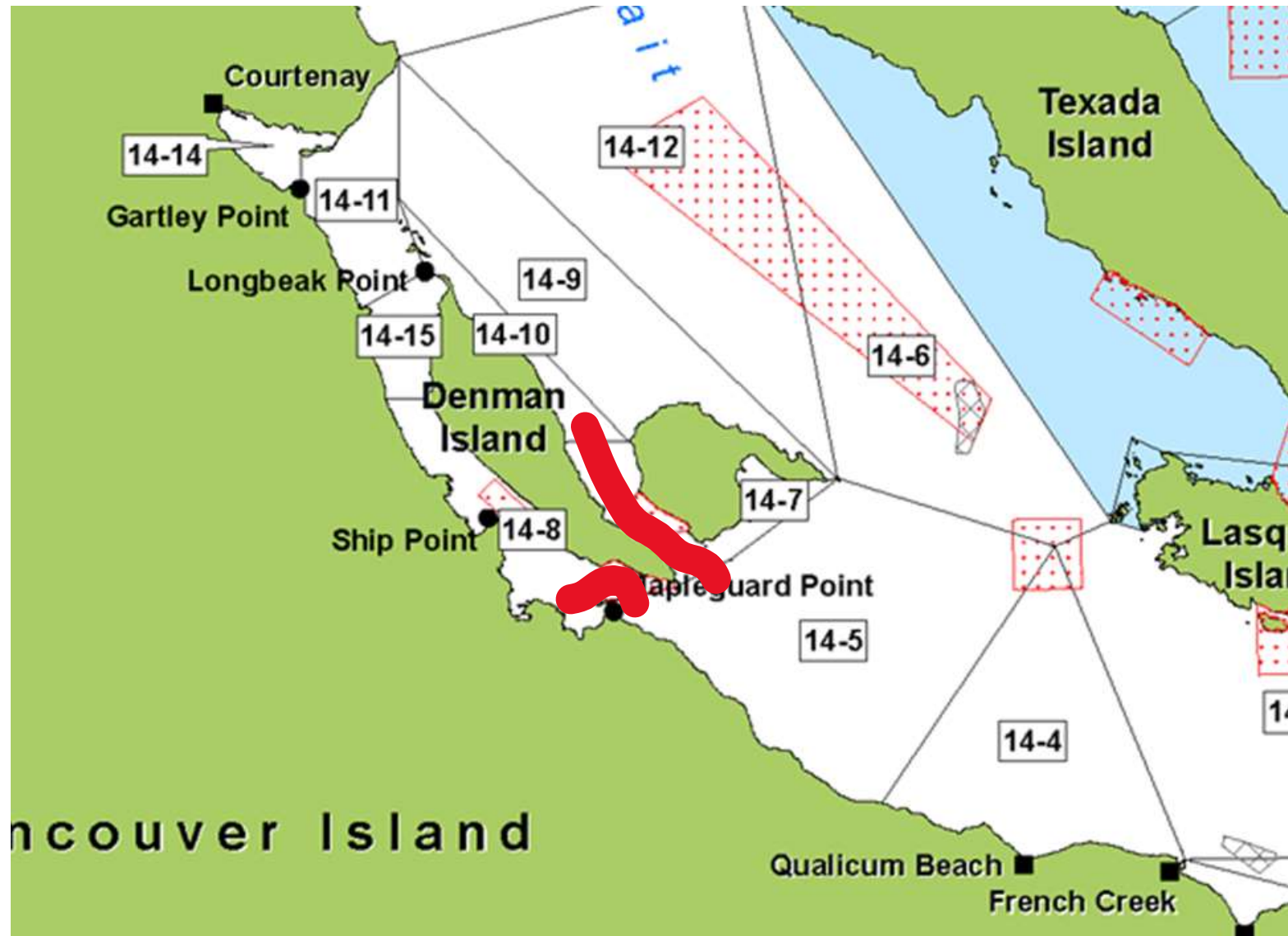
SOG Roe Seine Fishery - 2025

Resource Manager(s)	Eamon Miyagi, Christie Morrison
Catch Quota (short tons)	4899.3
Number of Licenses	215 HS/77 ZM
Tons per License	HS – 19.492/ ZM - 7.9365
License Pools	7
Fishery Opening Date	March 9, 2025 at 18:00hrs
Fishery Closure Date	March 14, 2025 at 15:00hrs
Validated Catch (short tons)	3002.5
Areas Fished	14-5, 14-7, 14-8, 14-10



Packer pumping herring, Mar 2023

SOG Roe Seine Fishery - 2025



SOG Roe Gillnet Fishery - 2025

Resource Manager(s)	Andrea Haas
Catch Quota (short tons)	4,837
Number of Licenses	1,185
Tons per License	4.082
License Pools	14
Fishery Opening Date	March 5, 2025 at 14:00hrs
Brief Closure	March 10 at 20:00 – March 11 at 18:00
Fishery Closure Date	March 13, 2025 at 18:00hrs
Validated Catch (short tons)	4,795
Areas Fished	14-1, 14-7, 14-8, 14-10, 14-11 to 14-13

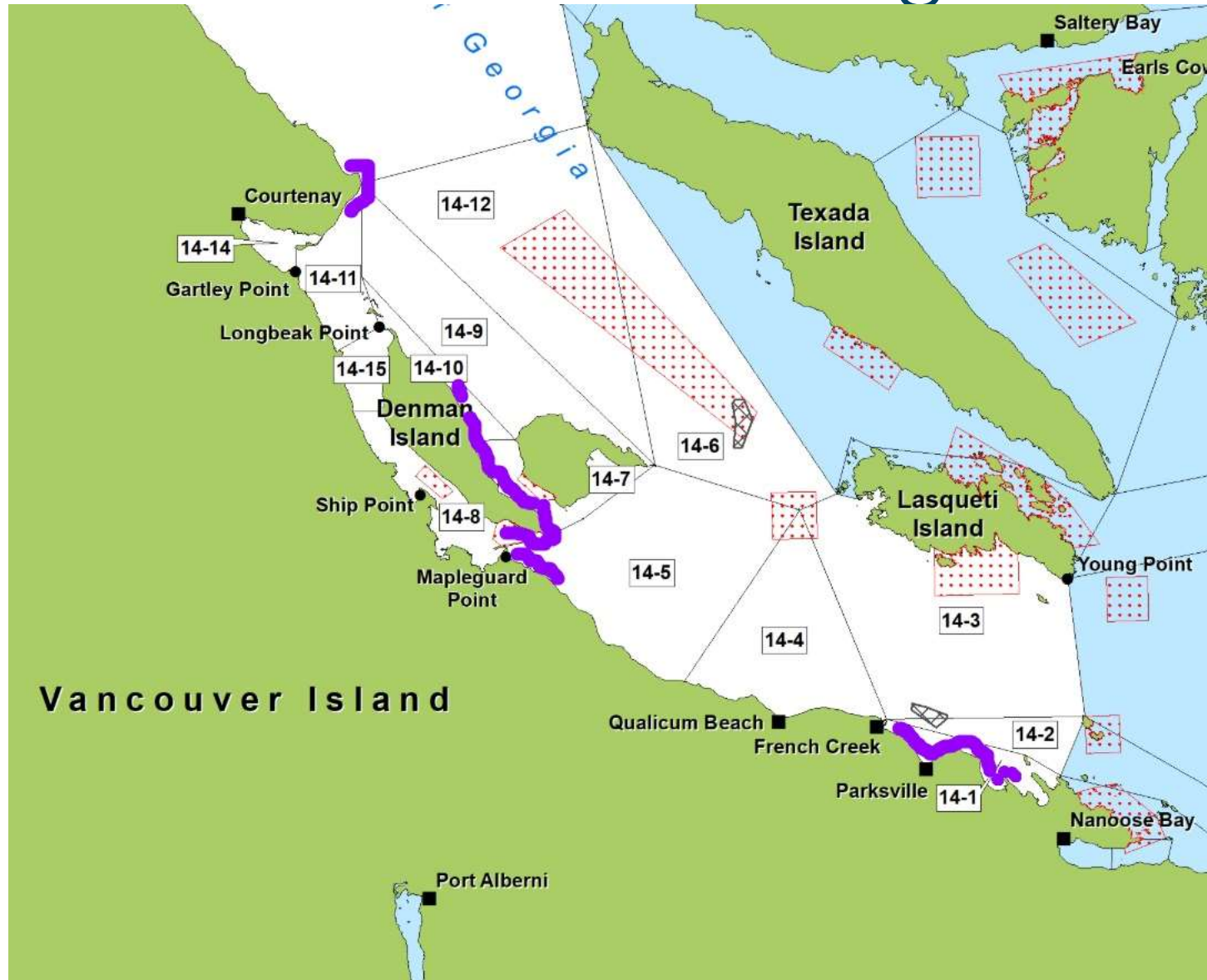


Gill net fleet, Mar 5 near Denman Isl.



Gill net punt and packer, Mar 12 near Parksville Bay

SOG Roe Gillnet Fishing 2025



Area Notes

- Fish behavior proved challenging for the seine fishery
 - Spawning began prior to fishery opening
 - Large concentrations of staging fish were not consistently found prior to fisheries
- Greater spatial and temporal distribution of spawn than past couple of years.



DFO Management Platform Viking Tide, Mar 2025
Credit: Facebook, West Coast Fishermen

Discussion - Successes

- Successful use of Whatsapp for in-season communication within roe fisheries groups – efficient information sharing.
- C&P presence (both C&P and joint Aquaculture C&P/TC/ECCC)
- Food and bait - roe seine quota transfer
- Good weather during the food and bait fishery
- IMAWG Facebook Spawn Reporting Page
- Greater spatial and temporal spawn distribution than last year(s)



Seine vessel, Hornby Island 2023

Discussion: Challenges

Roe gillnet fishery:

- Inconsistent off-grounds catch reporting leading to uncertainty of catch and premature fishery closure (precautionary management)
- Gill net fishery closed for 22 hours due to delays in catch reporting
- Lost or abandoned fishing gear – gear marking

Roe seine fishery:

- Fish were not found in concentrated abundance on the fishing grounds
- Quota not achieved
- Highly visible and subject to public scrutiny
- Roe seine/food and bait quota transfers

Overall:

- Incidents of unlicensed vessels packing
- Delays in fishery notice publication due to translation requirements.

Norovirus concerns:

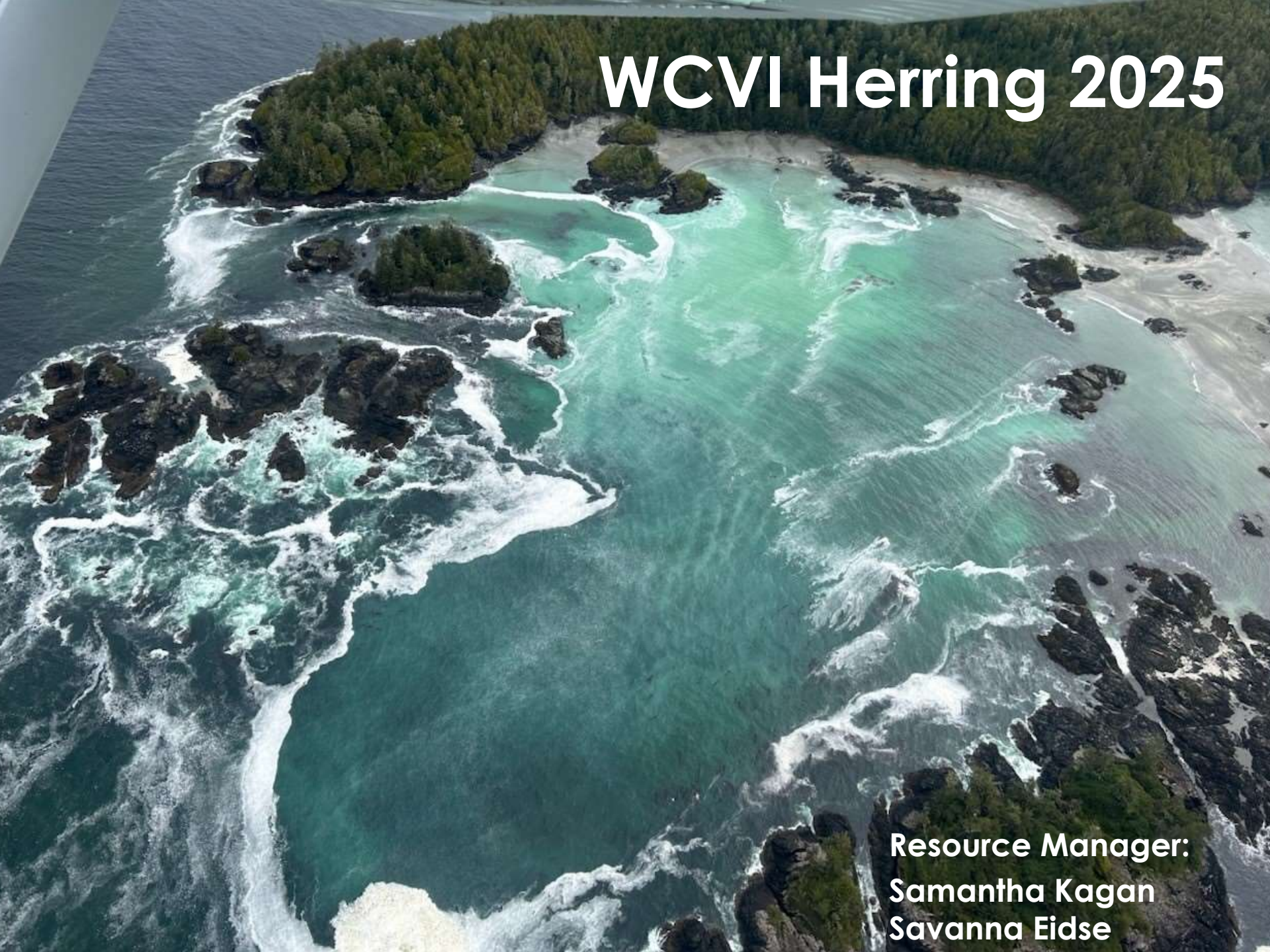
- Shellfish aquaculture closures occurred pre-emptively due to vessel concentration thresholds.



Seine Test Fishing, March 2025

Questions and Discussion

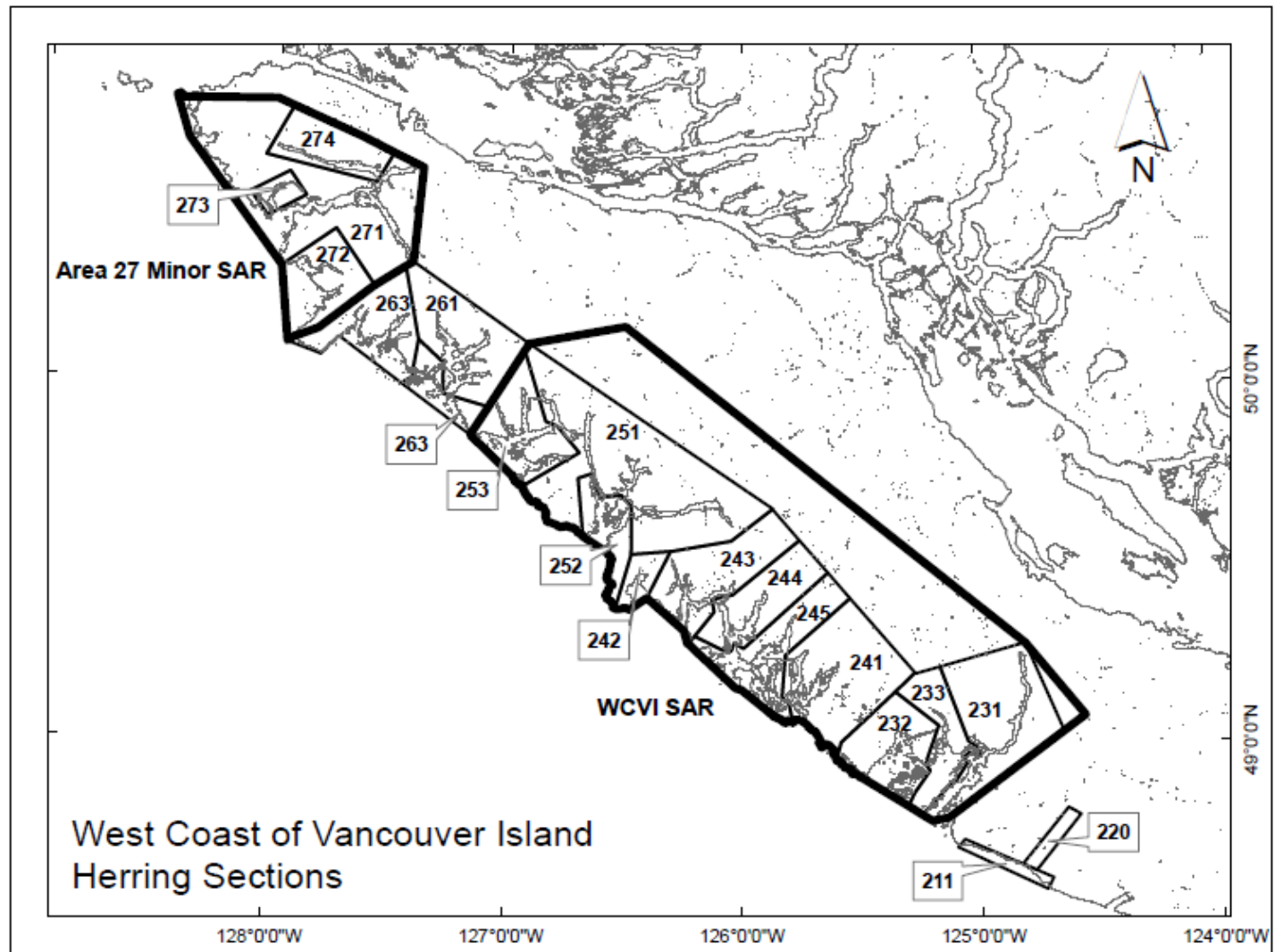


An aerial photograph of a coastal area. The water is a vibrant turquoise color, with white surf breaking over dark, jagged rocks. The shoreline is covered in dense green forest. The overall scene is a mix of natural elements: water, rocks, and forest.

WCVI Herring 2025

Resource Manager:
Samantha Kagan
Savanna Eidse

WCVI Herring Stock Assessment Areas



Harvest Level Decision Context - WCVI

- WCVI Major Stock Assessment Area:
 - 2025 spawning biomass was forecasted to be 65,894 (36,824 – 229,078) tons, with a 0% probability of being below the LRP in the absence of fishing
 - Fisheries:
 - five Nations right-based sale (open pond)
 - Commercial spawn-on-kelp (4 eligible SOK licences)
- Area 27 Minor Stock Assessment Area:
 - Spawn index for 2024 is 9,671 tons
 - FSC and Spawn on Kelp herring opportunities to a maximum of 105 tons
 - Three SOK licences were assigned to the area in total

WCVI Area Herring Resources for 2025

Test vessel: *Western Investor*: 17-day charter (February 19 – March 8)

Dive charters:

- Vessel-based: *Pachena No.1*: 20-day charter (March 12– March 27)
 - Only 19 charter days used
- Shore-based: *Seaveyor 1*: 15-day charter (February 17-18, March 12-24)

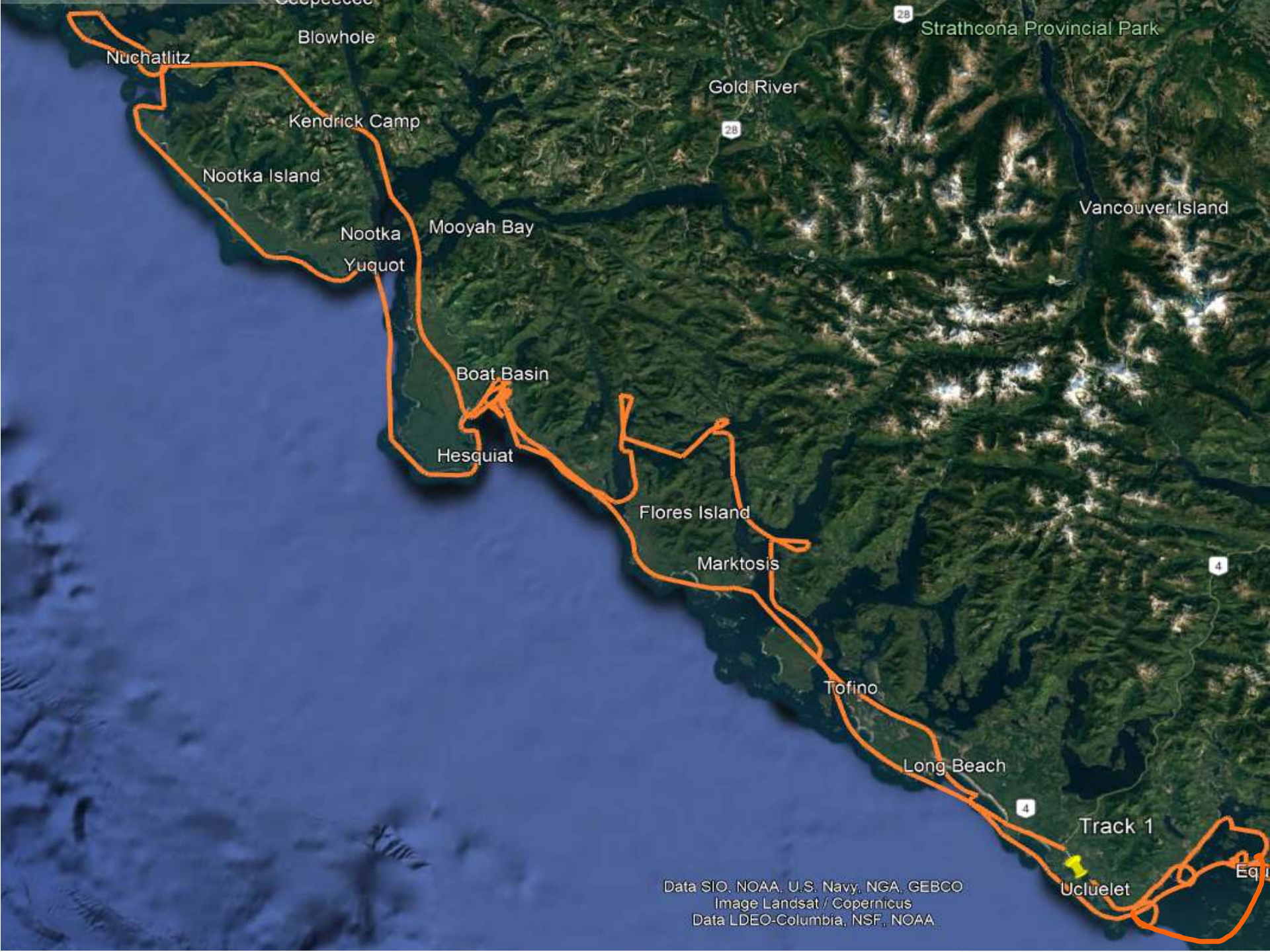
Herring Spawn Reconnaissance Flights:

- 11 overflights conducted between March 3 and March 28

First Nations' Herring Spawn Survey

Contracts:

- **Area 23:** 23 days
 - **NTC Biologist:** Sabrina Crowley
 - Northern Barkley Sound - 15 days (Feb 15- Mar 31)
 - **Toquaht First Nation:** Aline Carrier
 - Southern Barkley Sound – 8 days (Feb 15- Mar 31)
 - **Huu-ay-aht First Nation:** Scott Cheyne
- **Area 24:** 31 days
 - **NTC Biologist:** Carilia Horning
 - Hesquiat Harbour, Clayoquot Sound (Feb 15 to Mar 31)
 - **Hesquiaht First Nation:** Rufus Charleson
- **Area 25:** 26 days
 - **NTC Biologist:** Danielle Robertson
 - Nootka Sound:
 - **Mowachaht/Muchalaht First Nation:** Justin Blondeau
 - Esperanza Inlet
 - **Ehattesaht First Nation:** Tyler Hanson, Shelly Hamilton
 - **Nuchatlaht First Nation:** Judae Smith, Roger Dunlop



Blowhole

Strathcona Provincial Park

Nuchatlitz

Gold River

Kendrick Camp

Vancouver Island

Nootka Island

Nootka

Mooyah Bay

Yuquot

Boat Basin

Hesquiat

Flores Island

Marktosia

Tofino

Long Beach

Track 1

Ucluelet

Data SIO, NOAA, U.S. Navy, NGA, GEBCO
Image Landsat / Copernicus
Data LDEO-Columbia, NSF, NOAA

WCVI Spawn Flight Observations

Area	3-Mar	6-Mar	9-Mar	12-Mar	14-Mar	17-Mar	18-Mar	21-Mar	24-Mar	26-Mar
23	X	X	Mussel Beach to Toquart Bay Stopper Islands St. Ines Island Spilling Islet Rowland Islet Ottaway Islet David Island Bryant Islands Forbes Island	Nettle Island Erin Island	X	X	X	X	X	X
24	Hesquiat Harbour George Islands		Hesquiat Harbour	Whitesand Cove Hesquiat Harbour	Whitesand Cove	Hotsprings Cove	Hesquiat Harbour S. of Clifford Point	Hesquiat Harbour Matilda Inlet	Bartlett Island Whaler Islet	Hesquiat Harbour Bartlett Island
25	Friendly Cove Santa Gertrudis Cove to McKay Passage Beano Creek	Friendly Cove Pantoja Islands Spouter Island Clotchman Island Santa Gertrudis Cove to Marvinas Bay Saavedra Islands Bajo Point	Skuna Bay	X	X	X	X	X	X	X

Herring Assessment Summary: WCVI 2025

- Active spawn reported or observed between January 9 and April 27
- 71,500 tons were sounded (includes both passes in each area)
- 64 nm of estimated spawn was recorded
- Vessel and shore-based dive surveys were performed on all observed spawn areas except for early Hesquiat Harbour, Bartlett Island, Whaler Islet, outside of Nootka Island, Quatsino Sound, late Ucluelet Harbour, and late Nootka Sound.
- 16 seine test-samples were taken by test vessel *Western Investor*.
- 18 cast-net samples were taken by First Nation Charters.

Herring Sample Summary

Area	Purse Seine	Cast Net
23	4	1
24	7	16
25-Nootka	3	1
25-Esperanza	2	0
Total	16	18

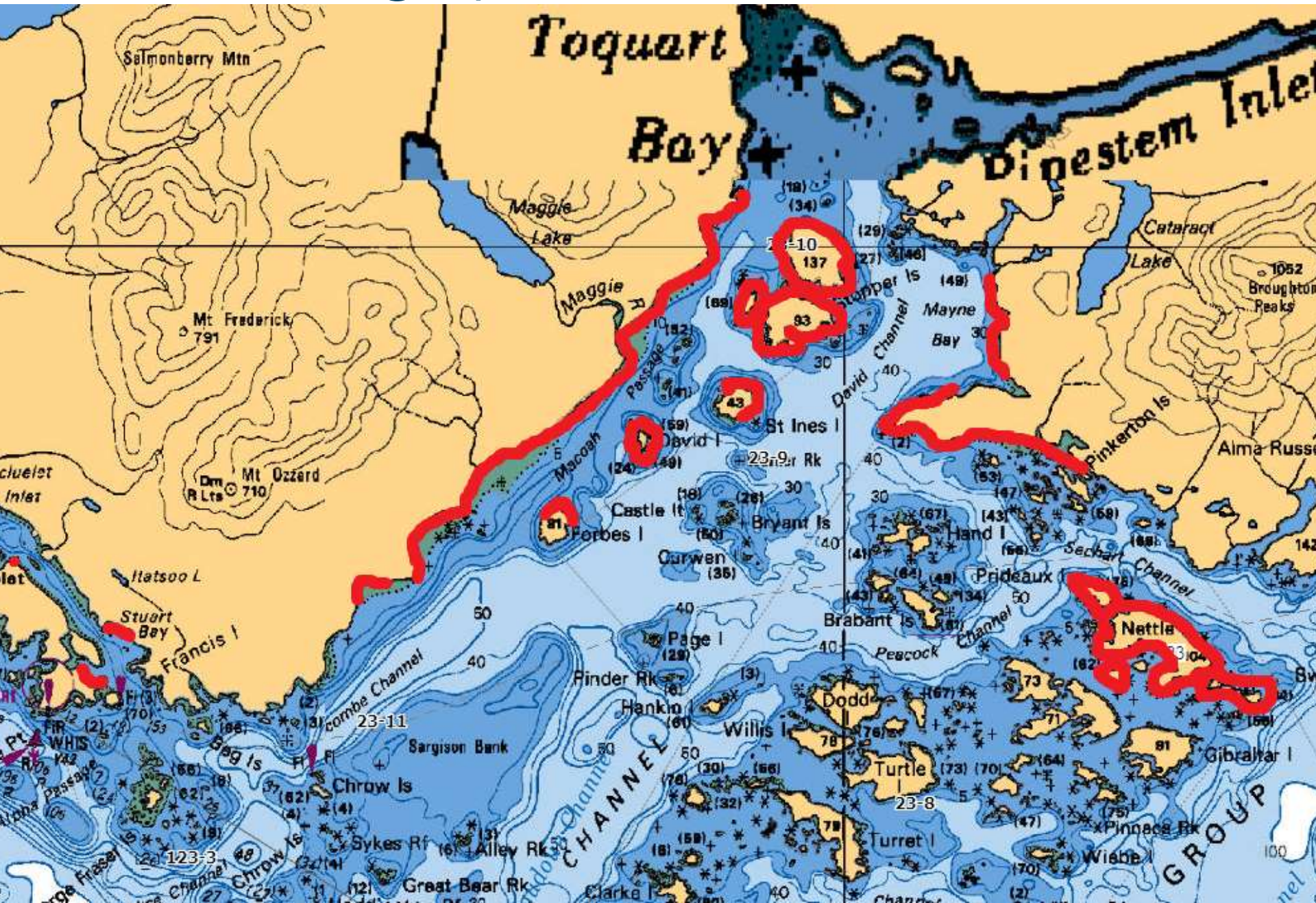
Herring Assessment Summary: Area 23

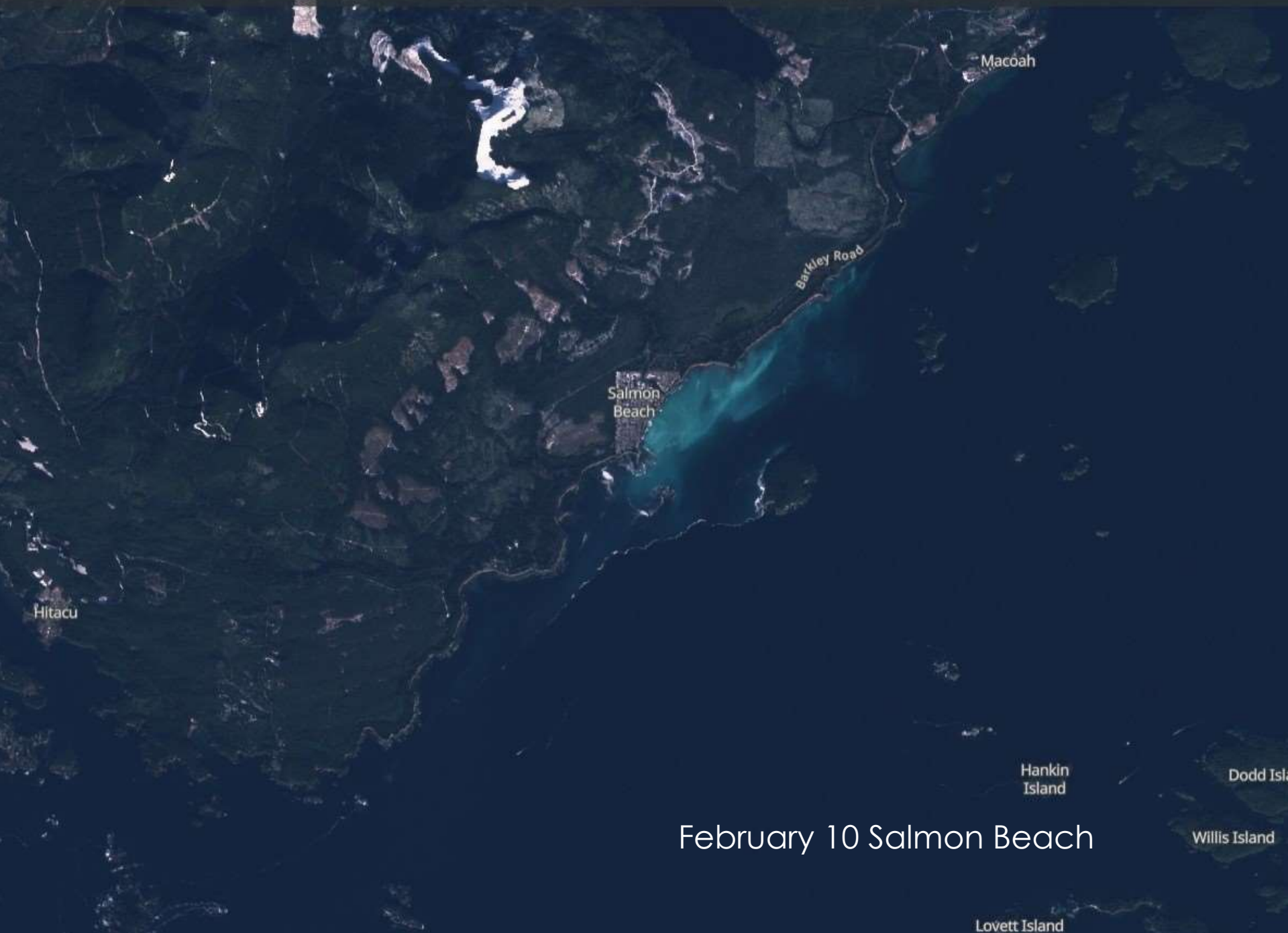
- Spawn reported and observed between February 10 and April 9
- 2,500 tons were sounded between February 19 and 20.
- 20,000 tons were sounded between March 5 and 8.
- 23nm of spawn activity was recorded.
- Shore-based dive surveys were conducted in all areas where active spawn had been observed, except for the April 9 spawn in Ucluelet Harbour
- 4 seine test-samples were taken by the test-vessel *Western Investor*
- 1 cast-net sample was taken by Toquaht First Nation and NTC.

2025 Herring Spawn: Area 23

- **February 10-11:**
 - Salmon Beach
- **March 7-12:**
 - Salmon Beach to Toquart Bay
 - Stopper Islands
 - Hermit Islets
 - Larkins Island
 - Spilling Islet
 - Rowlands Islets
 - Ottaway Islet
 - St. Ines Island
- **March 7-12 cont'd:**
 - David Island
 - Bryant Islands
 - Forbes Island
 - Nettle Island
 - Spring Cove
 - Stuart Bay
 - Reek Island
 - Equis Beach
- **April 9:**
 - Ucluelet Harbour

2025 Herring Spawn Locations: Area 23





February 10 Salmon Beach



March 8 David Island



March 8 Maggie River



March 12 Erin Island

Herring Assessment Summary:

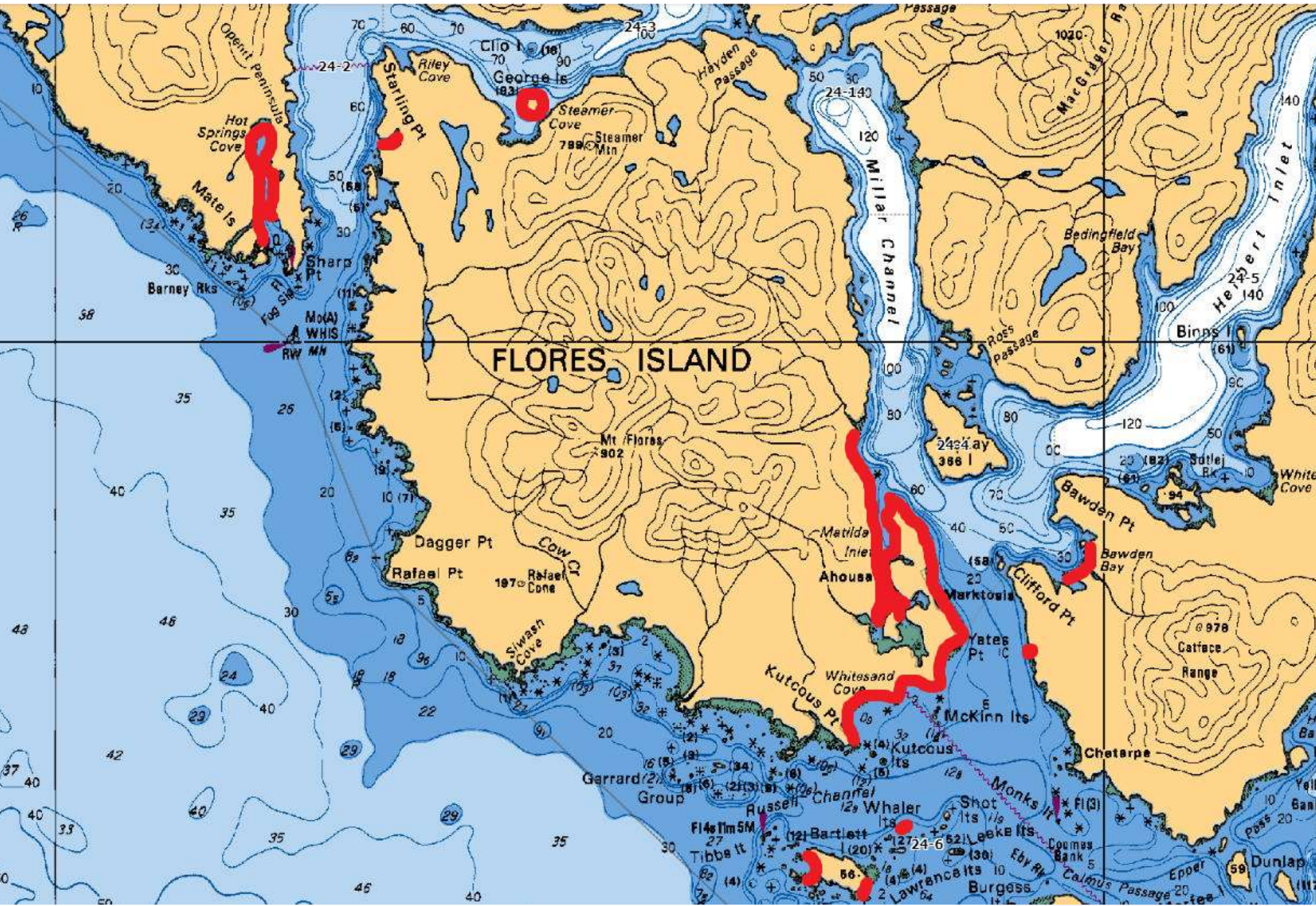
Area 24

- Active spawn reported and observed from January 9 to March 26
- 8,000 tons were sounded between February 21 and 23.
- 11,000 tons were sounded between March 3 and 5.
- 27nm of spawn was recorded.
- Vessel and shore-based dive surveys were carried out on all spawn locations except early Hesquiat Harbour, Bartlett Island and Whaler Islet
- 7 seine test samples were taken by the test-vessel *Western Investor*
- 16 cast-net samples were taken by Hesquiaht First Nation and NTC.

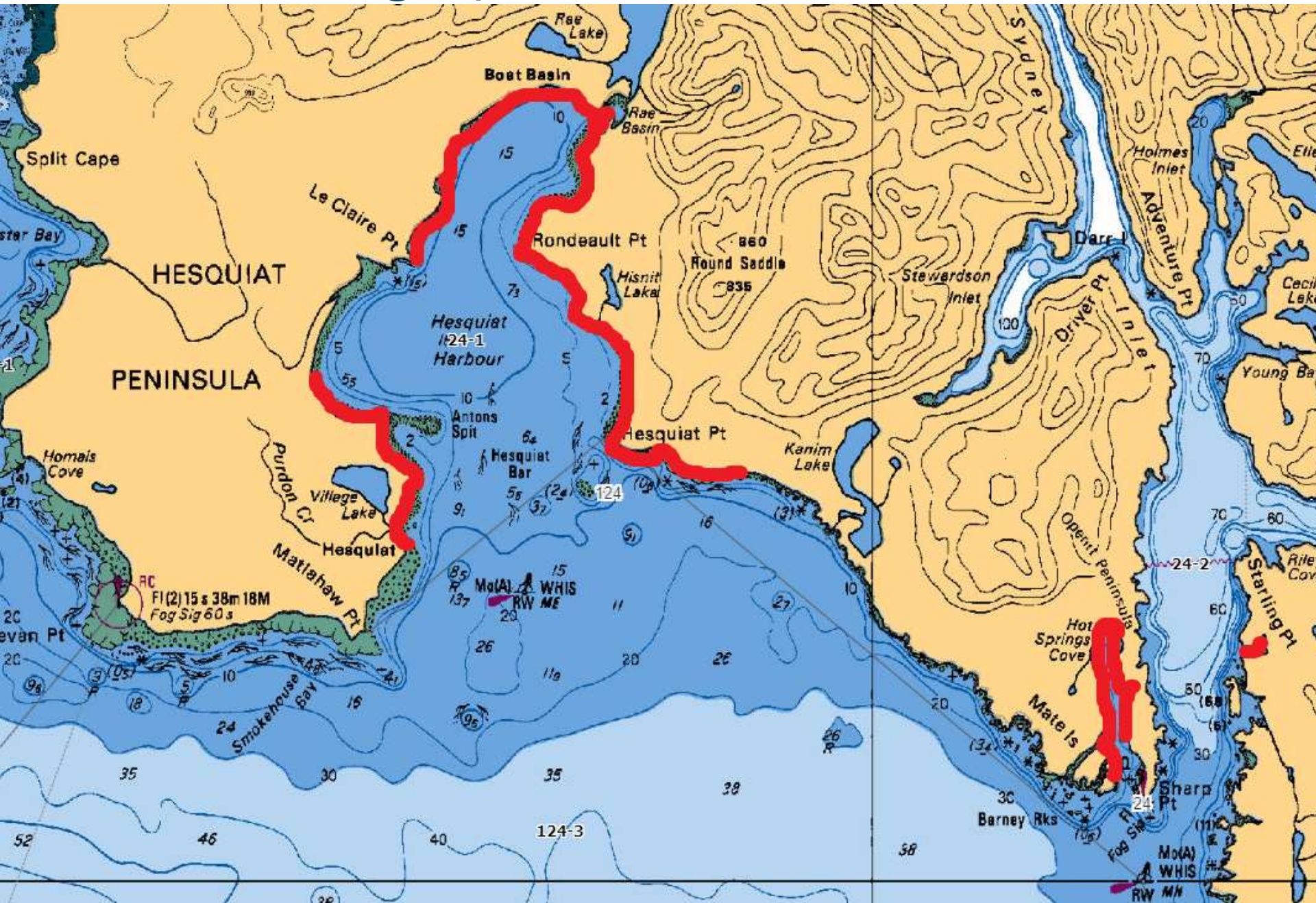
2025 Herring Spawn: Area 24

- **January 9:**
 - Hesquiat Harbour
- **February 13:**
 - Hesquiat Harbour
- **February 28:**
 - Bawden Bay
- **March 2-3:**
 - Hesquiat Harbour
 - George Islands
- **March 7-12:**
 - Hootla Kootla Bay
 - Hesquiat Harbour
 - Whitesand Cove
- **March 14-18**
 - Hot springs cove
 - Matilda Inlet
 - Clifford Point
 - Hesquiat Harbour
- **March 21-26**
 - Hesquiat Harbour
 - Matilda Inlet
 - Bartlett Island
 - Whaler Islets

2025 Herring Spawn Locations: Area 24



2025 Herring Spawn Locations: Area 24





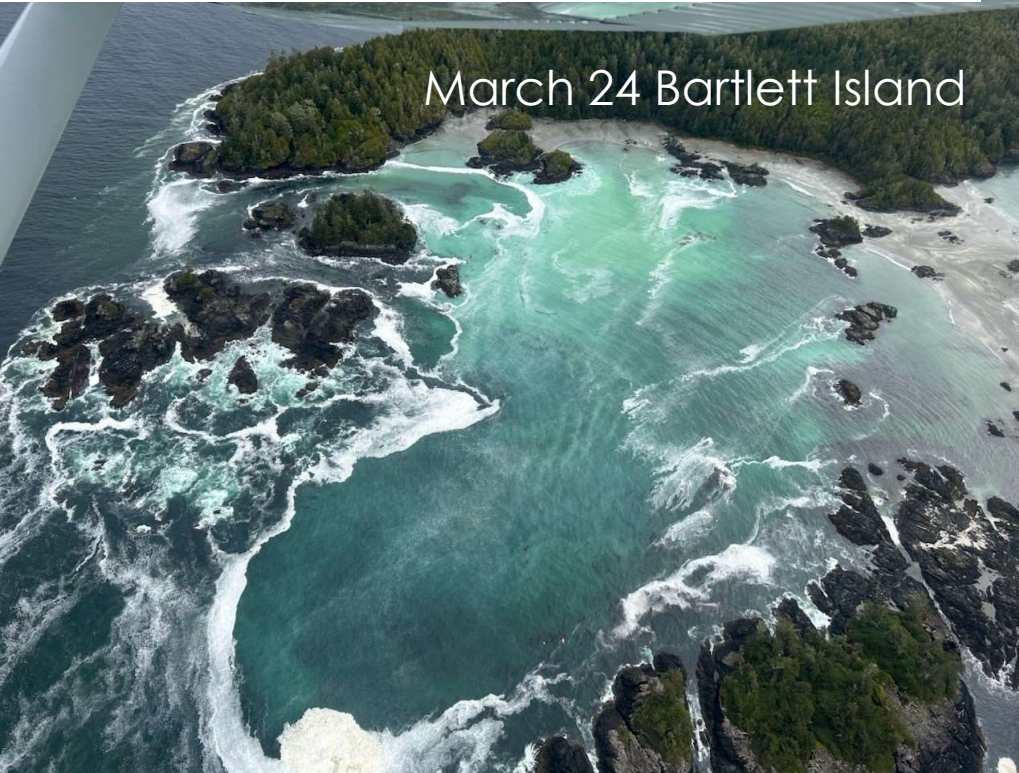
March 3 George Islands



March 12 Whitesand Cove



March 18 Hesquiat Harbour



March 24 Bartlett Island



March 18
South of Clifford Pt



Herring Assessment Summary: Area 25 (Nootka)

- Active spawn reported and observed from February 27 – April 27
- 20,000 tons sounded between March 1 and March 3
- 10 nm of spawn recorded
- Vessel-based dive surveys were conducted in areas where active spawn had been observed except for outer Nootka Island (Beano Creek, Bajo Reef, Skuna Bay) and the April 27 Nootka Island spawn
- 1 cast net sample was taken by Mowachaht/Muchalaht First Nation and NTC
- 3 seine test samples were taken by the test-vessel *Western Investor*

2025 Herring Spawn:

Area 25 (Nootka)

- **February 27-28:**

- Friendly Cove

- **March 3:**

- Friendly Cove
- Santa Gertrudis Cove to McKay Passage
- Beano Creek

- **March 6:**

- Pantoja Islands
- Spouter and Clotchman Islands
- Santa Gertrudis Cove to Marvinas Bay

- **March 6 cont'd:**

- Saavedra Islands
- Bajo Point

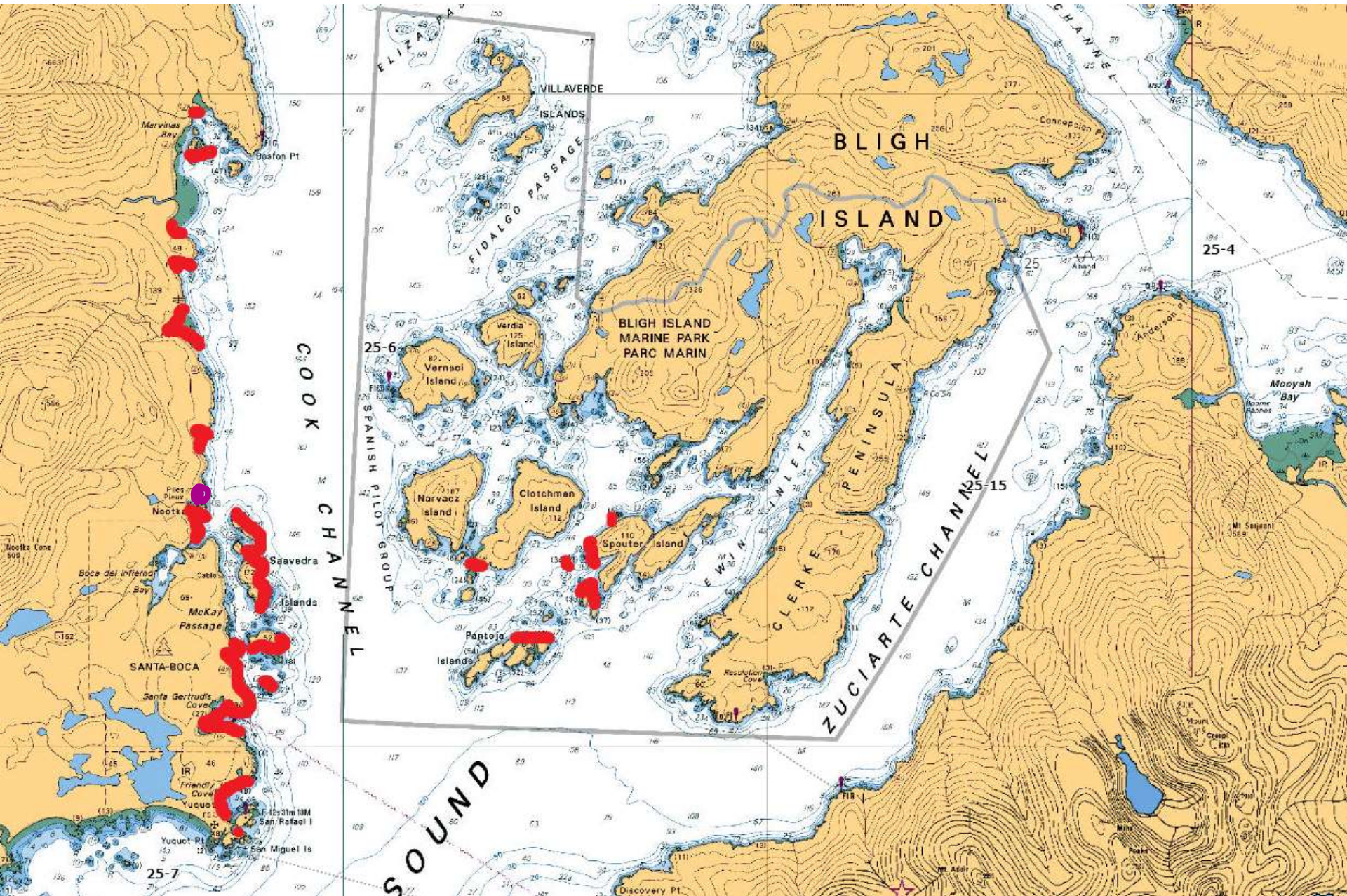
- **March 9:**

- Skuna Bay

- **April 27**

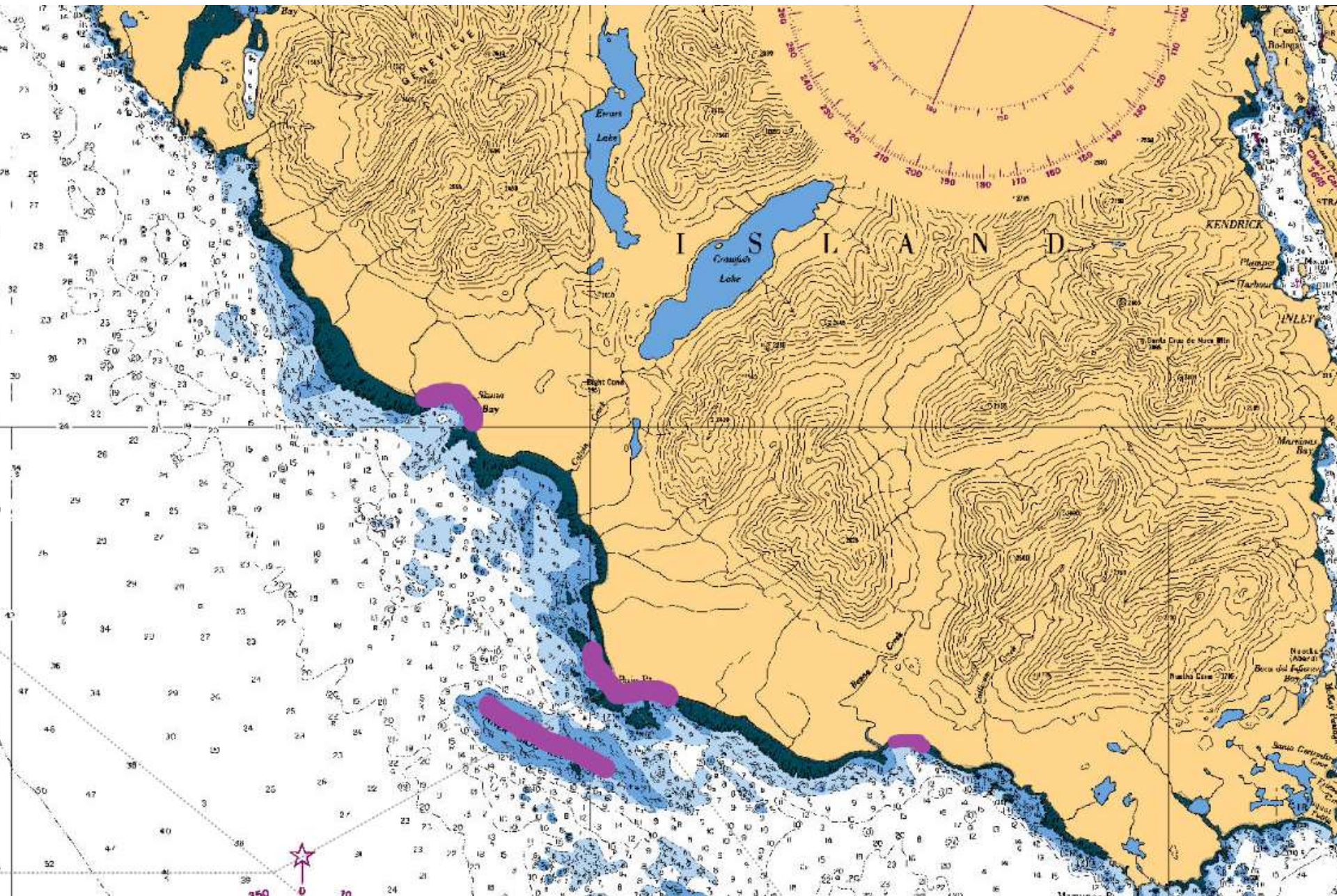
- Nootka Island shoreline NW of Saavedra Islands

Nootka



2025 Herring Spawn Locations: Area 25

Nootka





March 3 Beano Creek



March 6 Bajo Pt



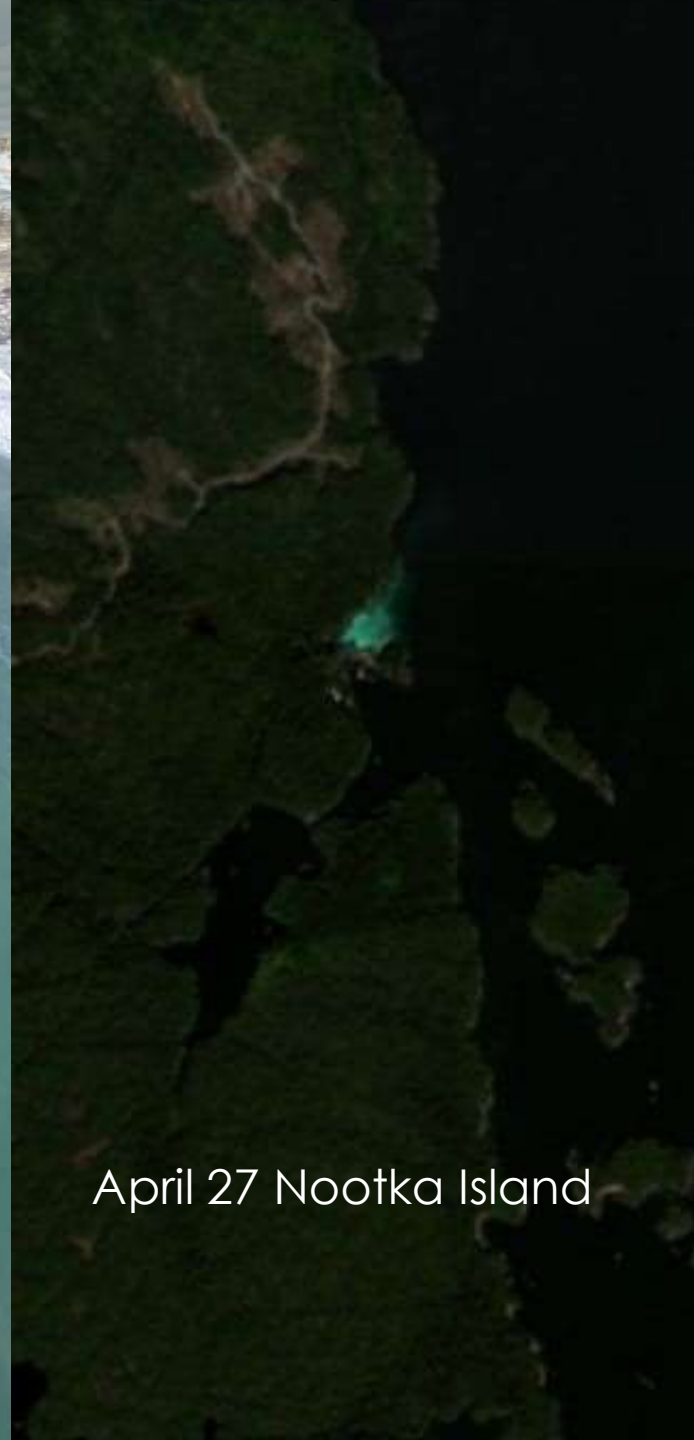
60 March 6 Clotchman Island



March 6 Pantoja Islands



March 8 Skuna Bay



April 27 Nootka Island

Herring Assessment Summary: Area 25 (Esperanza)

- Active spawn reported and observed between February 6 to March 12
- 10,000 tons sounded
- 4nm of spawn recorded
- Vessel-based dive surveys were conducted in all areas where active spawn had been observed
- 2 seine test-samples was taken by the test-vessel *Western Investor*

2025 Herring Spawn: Area 25 (Esperanza)

- **February 6:**

- Port Langford

- **February 28:**

- Port Langford

- **March 3:**

- Benson Point
- Rosa Harbour
- Rosa Island
- Nuchatlitz

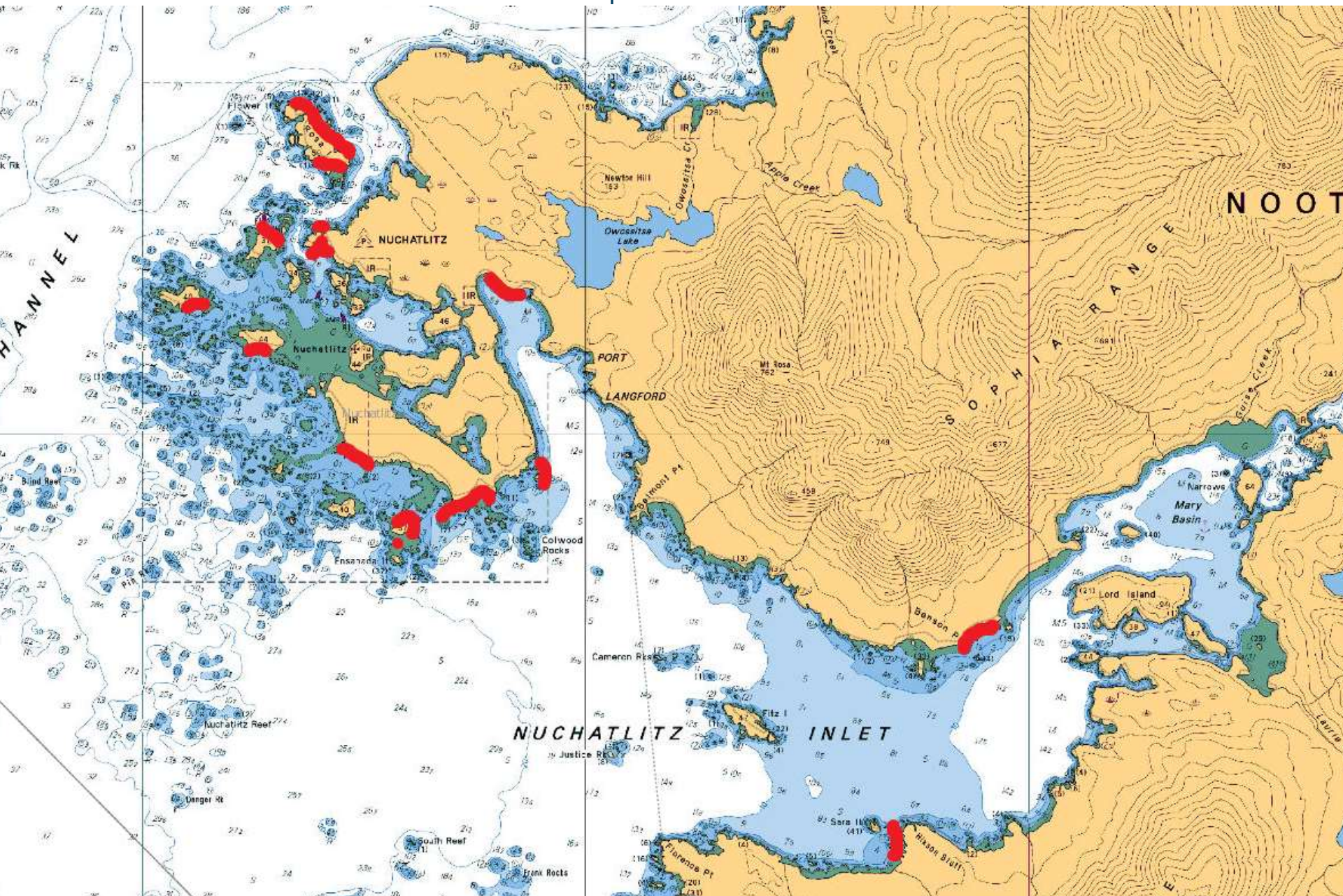
- **March 9:**

- Nuchatlitz

- **March 12:**

- Nuchatlitz
- Rosa Island
- Nootka Island behind Sara Islet

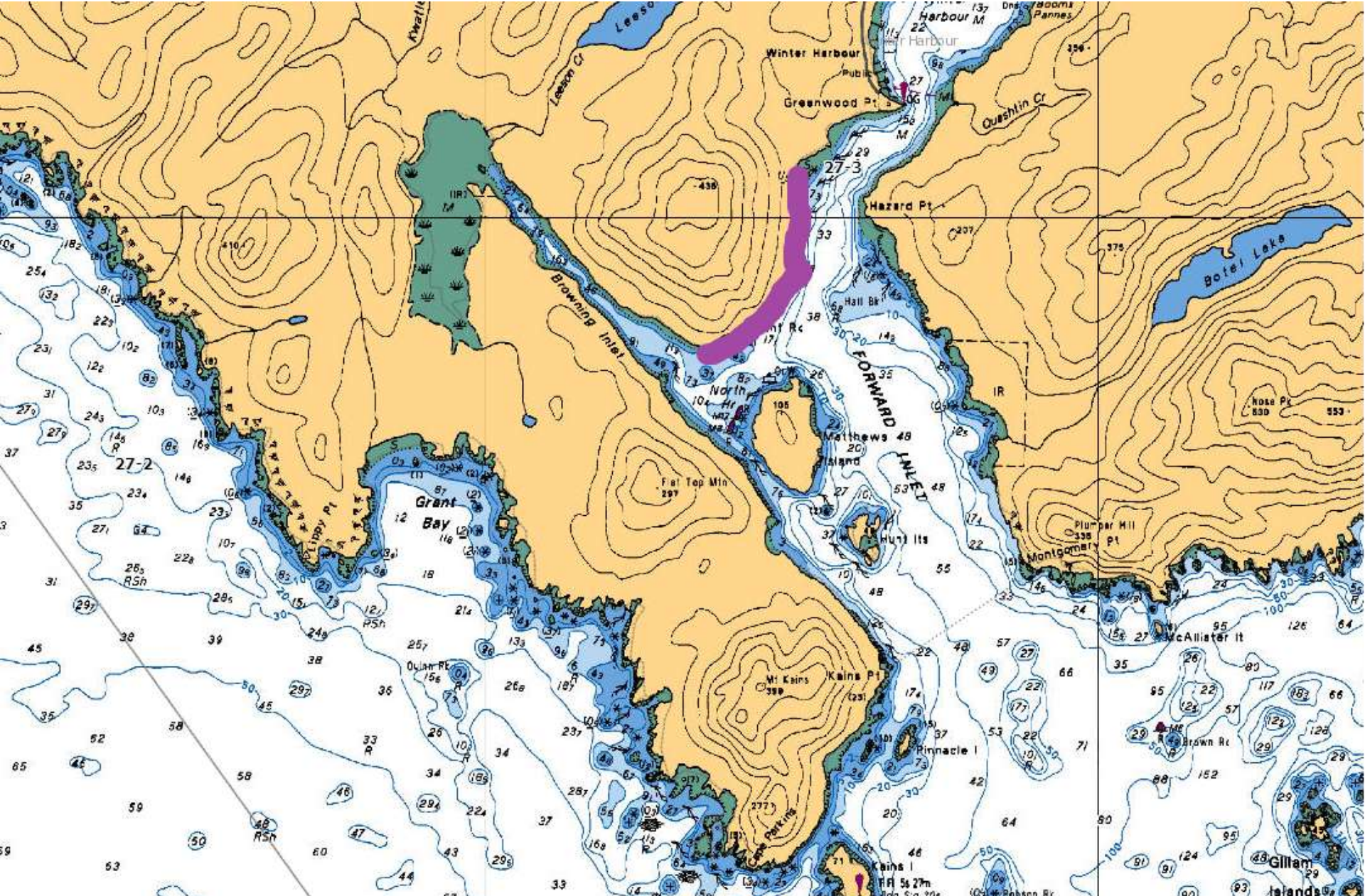
Esperanza



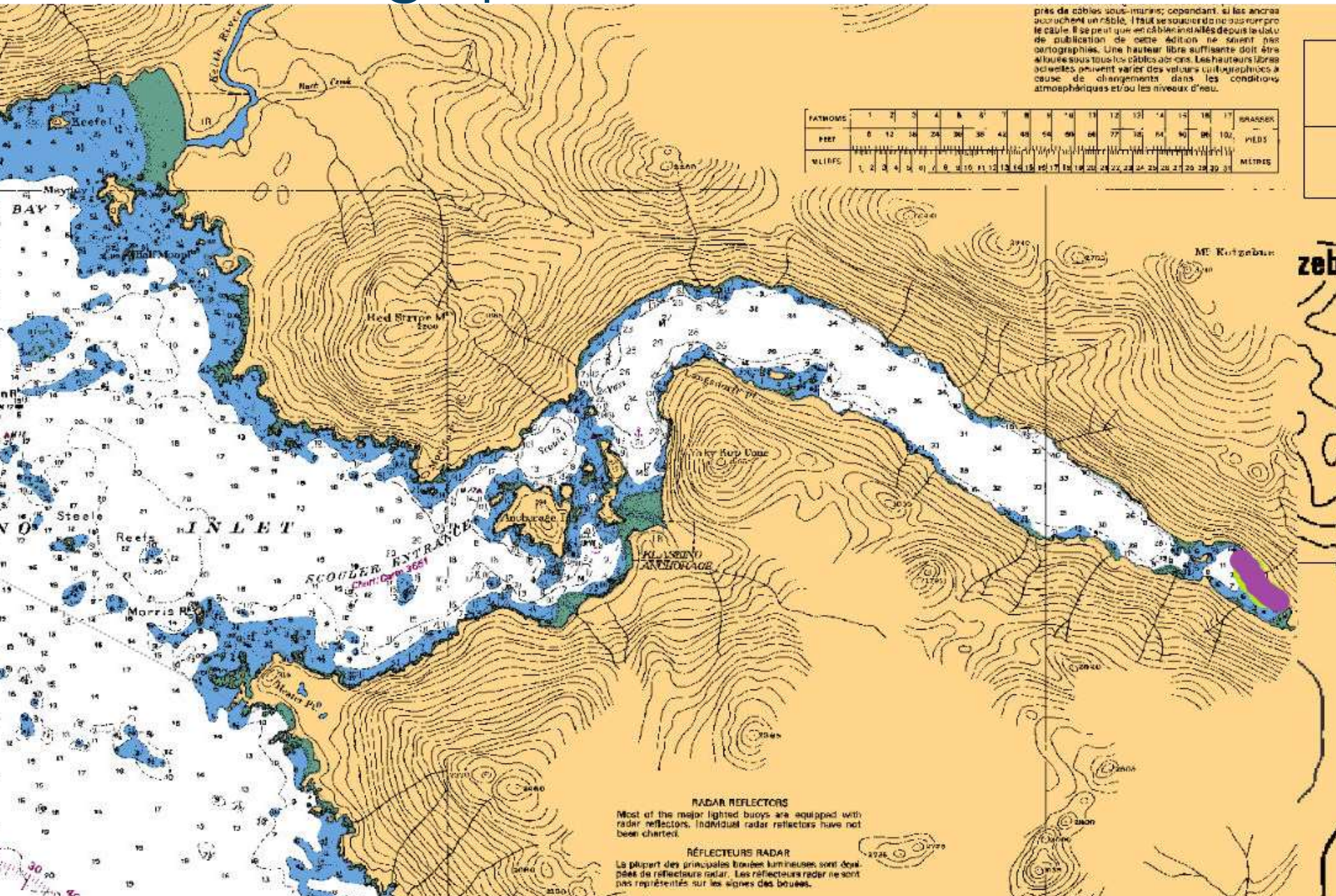
Herring Assessment Summary: Area 27

- Spawn reported in **Klaskino Inlet** (February 25) and **Forward Inlet** (occurred on March 5, reported on March 18)
- No dive surveys were carried out on Area 27 spawn due to resource availability and spawn report timing

2025 Herring Spawn Locations: Area 27



2025 Herring Spawn Locations: Area 27



WCVI Fisheries

- **FSC**

- Approximately 1,700 lbs pounds of whole Herring were reported collected by Nuu-chah-nulth Nations in 2025 from the test fishing vessel *Western Investor*.
- Anecdotal reports suggest improved FSC harvest in some areas, most notably in Area 23.

- **five Nations right-based sale fishery**

- Open pond spawn-on-kelp
- Opened February 28 in portions of PFMA 24, 25, 26
- Closed April 9
- TAC: 48,000 lbs
- Total validated catch: 30,235 lbs

- **Commercial closed-pond SOK**

- No J licences activated



Discussion

Successes

- Active spawn timing was widespread
- Increased FSC harvest - anecdotally
- In-season communication and collaboration between all parties
- Productive flights: 11 flights, on 10 of which active spawn was observed
- Flight tag-alongs: 7 passengers from First Nation partners
- High number of cast-net samples in Area 24, 2 more than in 2024
- five Nations right-based sale fishery for SOK opened for the first time



Discussion

Challenges

- No purse seine samples collected during the *Western Investors* first assessment in Barkley Sound
- Low number of cast-net samples in Area 23 and 25
- No dive survey on spawn observed at:
 - Hesquiat Harbour, Bartlett Island, Whaler Islet, outside of Nootka Island, late Ucluelet Harbour, and Quatsino Sound.
- Diver safety in high-traffic areas (Matilda Inlet)

Questions & Discussion



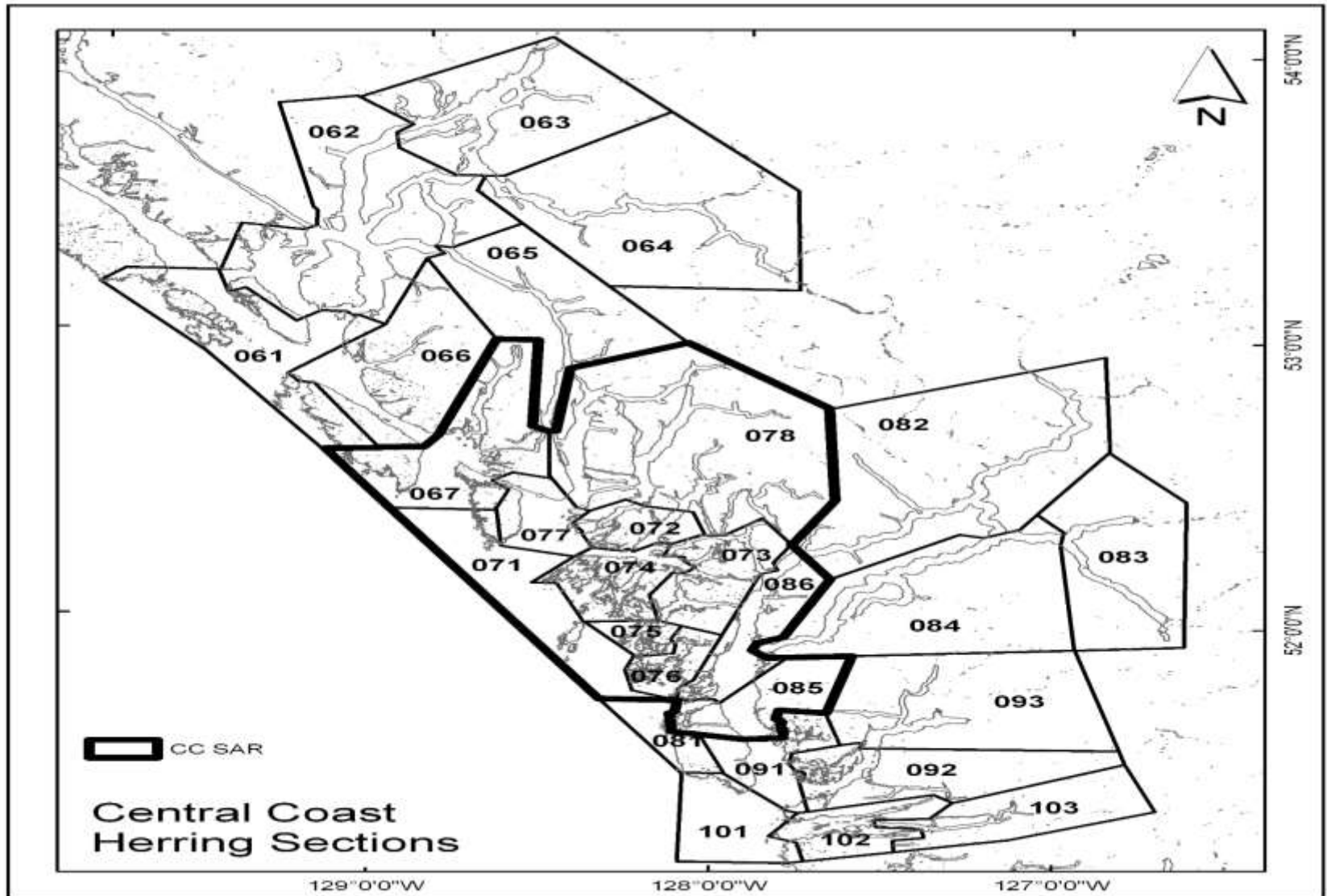


Central Coast 2025

Resource Managers:
Justin Savickas
Amanda Beckett



Stock Assessment Area – 6, 7, 8



Harvest Level Decision Context - CC

- Spawning biomass in 2025 is forecast to be 19,249 short tons (range: 9,888-38,583 tons) and to be below the LRP with a 32% probability in the absence of fishing.
- FSC and limited commercial Spawn on Kelp herring opportunities (4.7% harvest rate) to a maximum of 900 tons.

2025 Stock Assessment Resources

Dive Charters:

Pachena No.1	(April 5-20) 16 days
Ocean Cloud	(April 5-16) 12 days

Test Vessel:

Ocean Venture	(March 16 – April 7) 22 days
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Spawn Overflights: March 21, 27, 29, 31 April 3, 6, 8, 11

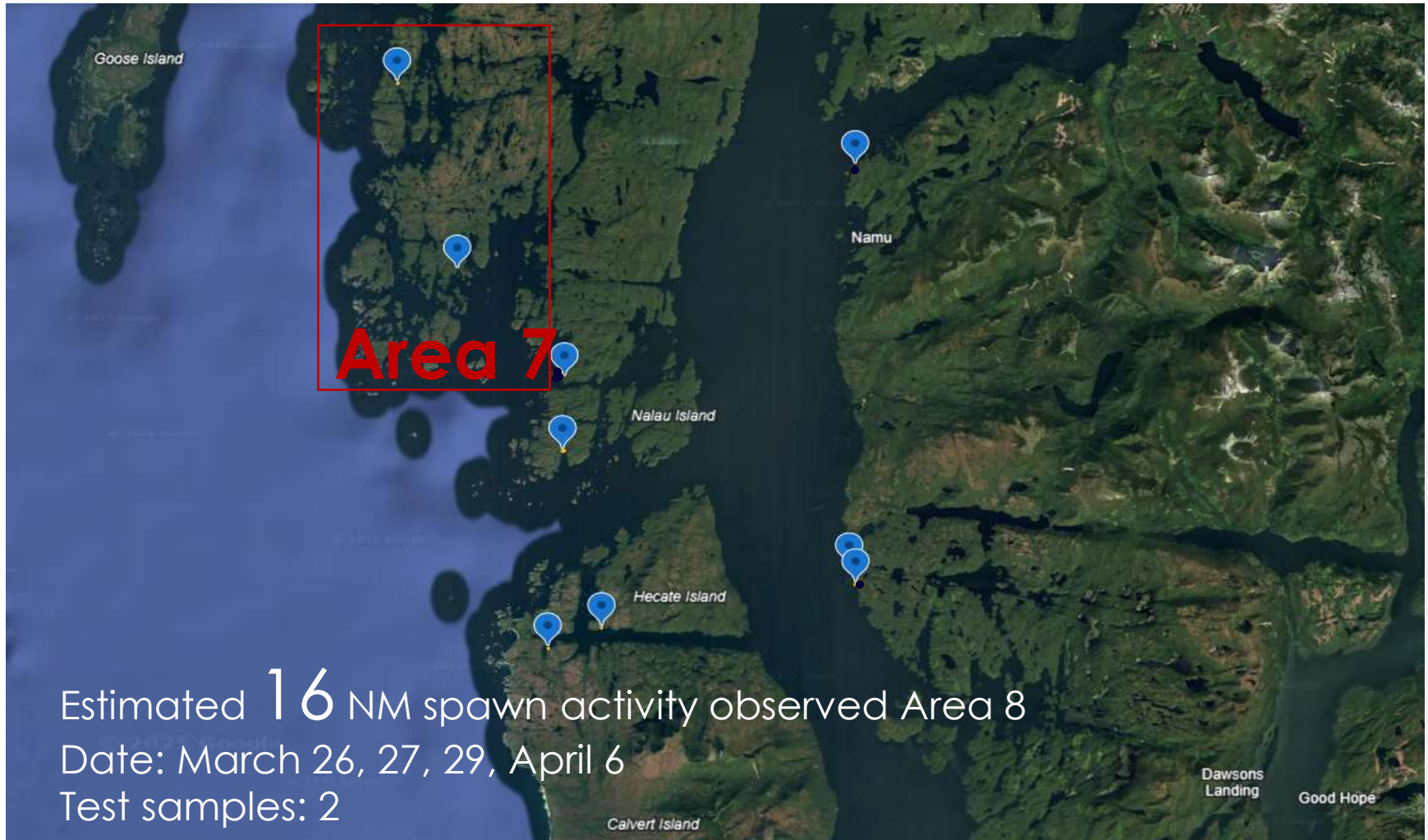
GN Sounding Platforms:

Dillon Sam	(March 27 – April 9)
Cheryl Lin 2	(March 20 – April 2)
Bradyne	(April 3 – April 15)
Pender Breeze	(March 13 – March 26)
Three Girls 2	(March 18 – March 31)

CC Spawn Flight Notes

- All flights were out of Port Hardy for the 2025 season.
- Wilderness Seaplane conducted overflights with a spotter and prepared reports for all flights. HIRMD staff member joined multiple flights during peak spawn.
- Total of 8 Flights: March 21, 27, 29, 31 April 3, 6, 8, 11
- Viewing conditions were generally good, allowing for complete coverage on all flights except one.

PFMA 8/7 - Spawn Observations



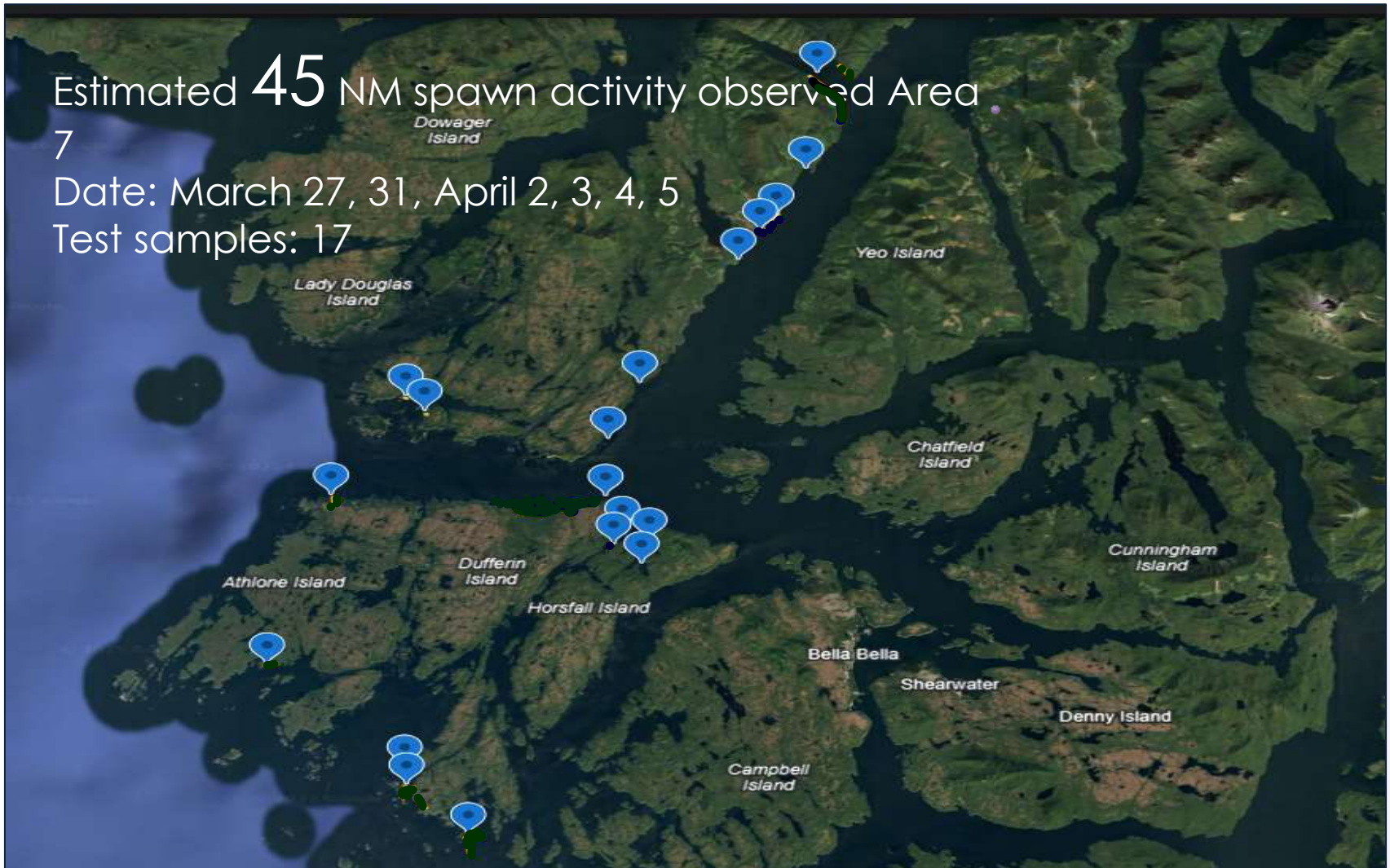
PFMA 7 - Spawn Observations

Estimated 45 NM spawn activity observed Area

7

Date: March 27, 31, April 2, 3, 4, 5

Test samples: 17



PFMA 6 - Spawn Observations



CC - Fisheries

- KITASOO XAI'XAIS
Commercial SOK &
FSC
- Heiltsuk FSC



Commercial Fishery Landings Breakdown

- Kitasoo spawn on kelp commercial fishery
- Areas 6 and portions of 7-3
- Fishery started March 14th
- Kitasoo fished 3 licenses with a quota of 47,647 lbs
- Quota was reached on April 5th



Area Notes

- First spawn reported on March 26 in Area 6 (Kitasu Bay)
- Sea surface temperatures through March and the start of April were unusually cold, averaging 5° c.
- Early indications of spawning activity were poor. Spawning conditions improved significantly as the season progressed.
- In Area 7, FSC (Food, Social, and Ceremonial) product was generally above average. Notable spawn layers observed in the lower Spiller Channel.

Discussion - Successes

- Total samples collected 20
- In-depth flight reports prepared by Wilderness Seaplanes
- Generally good weather resulted in minimal interference with the assessment program
- Communication between the DFO Area Manager and the Heiltsuk Herring Coordinator was good
- Thank you to everyone involved in this dynamic assessment program

Discussion – Challenges and Lessons Learned

- Additional coverage of Area 8 by gillnet-sounding vessels should be considered
- The efficiency of sounding coverage could be improved by distributing the gillnet and test vessel more evenly across the large area of the CC
- Reporting could be further improved with a standardized fillout sheet

Questions and Discussion





Prince Rupert District 2025

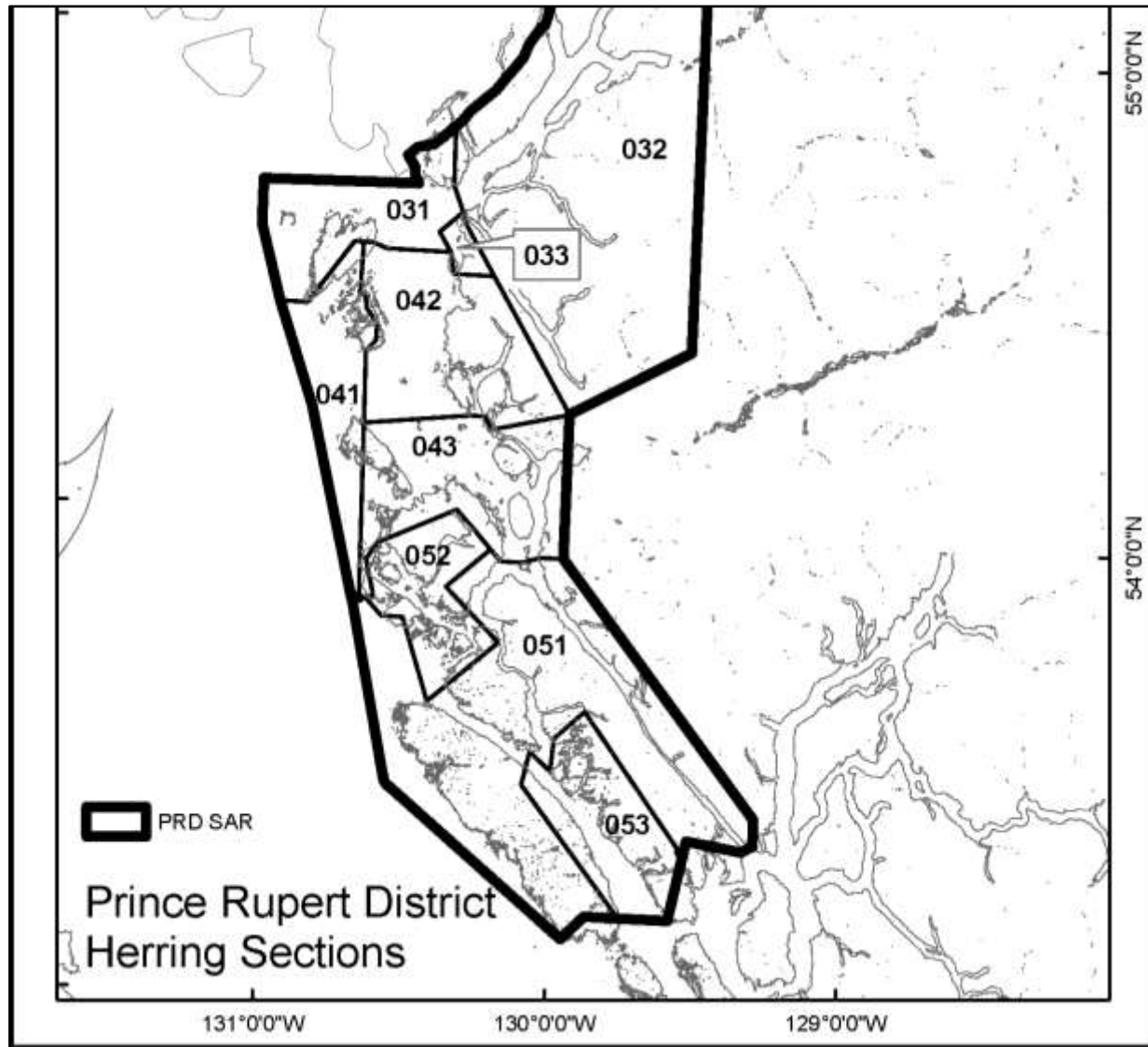
Resource Managers:

Area 4 Big Bay - Corey Martens

Area 5 Kitkatla - Karlana Lord



Stock Assessment Areas 4 & 5



Harvest Level Decision – PRD

- Spawning biomass was forecasted at 52,781 short tons (range: 28,264 - 92,387 tons) vs. 46,843 in 2024, with a 1% probability to be below the LRP in the absence of fishing
- 5% harvest rate applied for PRD
- Total TAC of 2,624 tons to support FSC (600 tons), SOK (1,000 tons) and roe herring (1,024 tons) :
 - SOK fishery did not occur
 - 461 tons identified for Gillnet (Area 4)
 - 12 licences – did not participate
 - 563 tons identified for Seine (Area 5)
 - 3 licences – did not participate

Stock Assessment Resources

Local DFO Contacts

Amanda Beckett Resource Manager – SOK Coordinator

Karlana Lord Resource Manager – Seine/Kitkatla (Area 5)

Corey Martens Resource Manager – Gillnet/Big Bay (Area 4)

Test Vessel

Area 4: Nita Maria

Area 5: Viking Spirit

Vessel Master

Brian Vogrig

Paul Brajcich

Operations

March 15 – 27

March 15 – 27

Dive Vessel

Royal Pride

Vessel Master

Arthur Malcolm

Operations

March 22 – April 10

Overflights

Inland Air Charters

Operations

March 18, 28, Apr 10

First Nations Contracts

Gitxaala Fisheries Program: Yota Kano, Colin Nelson

Lax Kw'alaams Fisheries: Bill Shepert, Katherine Pollock, Wade Helin

Metlakatla Aquatic Resources: Sarah Sankey, Ron Smith

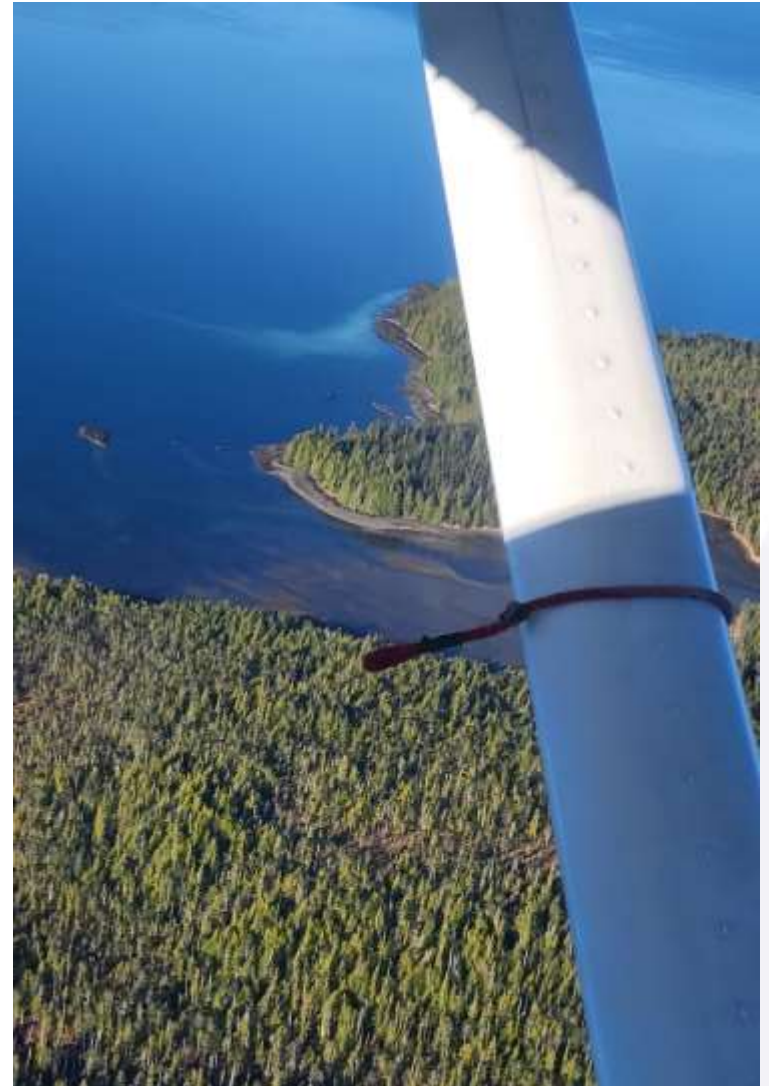
Spawn Flight Observations

Area 4 – Big Bay

March 18: small spawn observed south end of Burnt Cliff and South Isle. Large schools observed in the shallows. Light spawn leading from West Base Pt. west to Simpson Pt. Medium to large schools observed in the shallow from Slippery Rock south to Swamp Island. Active spawn observed south of Swamp to Ryan Pt.

March 28: Small spot spawn on the inside of Shattock Pt.

April 10: Spawn observed in Stumaun Bay along the shore at Bath Pt. and along the shore across the bay from Bath Pt.





April 10 flight observation of spawn at Stumaun Bay

Spawn Flight Observations

Area 5 - Kitkatla

March 18: Quiet along outside until Goschen Pt: Willis Bay (Moore Island), Shakes Islands, and Dolphin Lagoon all actively spawning with medium intensity. Large school of herring north of Shakes. Strong spawn North Dolphin (Kitkatla community docks – Shibasha Isl.) and strong spawn from Dries Inlet – Kitkatla Creek – partway to Snass Pt.

March 28: Active spot spawns prevalent: West Absalom, Joachim Pt x2, South Shakes, West Pragers x2, and Ness Islands x2. School noted between Ness and Snass Pt.

April 10: Active spot spawns SE Goschen x3, Freeman/Goschen x2, and Absalom Isl. X3. Strong spawn from Chief Pt – Gladstone Islands (Apr 9) had already dissipated.



March 28 flight observation of spawn in Shakes Islands/Willis Bay

Area 4 - Big Bay Notes

- Earliest spawn on record: exact time is unknown (Mar 12 first satellite imagery)
 - Possible contributing factor was a mild winter
- Spawns exhibited a spot spawn pattern throughout the season

PFMA 4 - Spawn Flight/Charter Vessel Observations



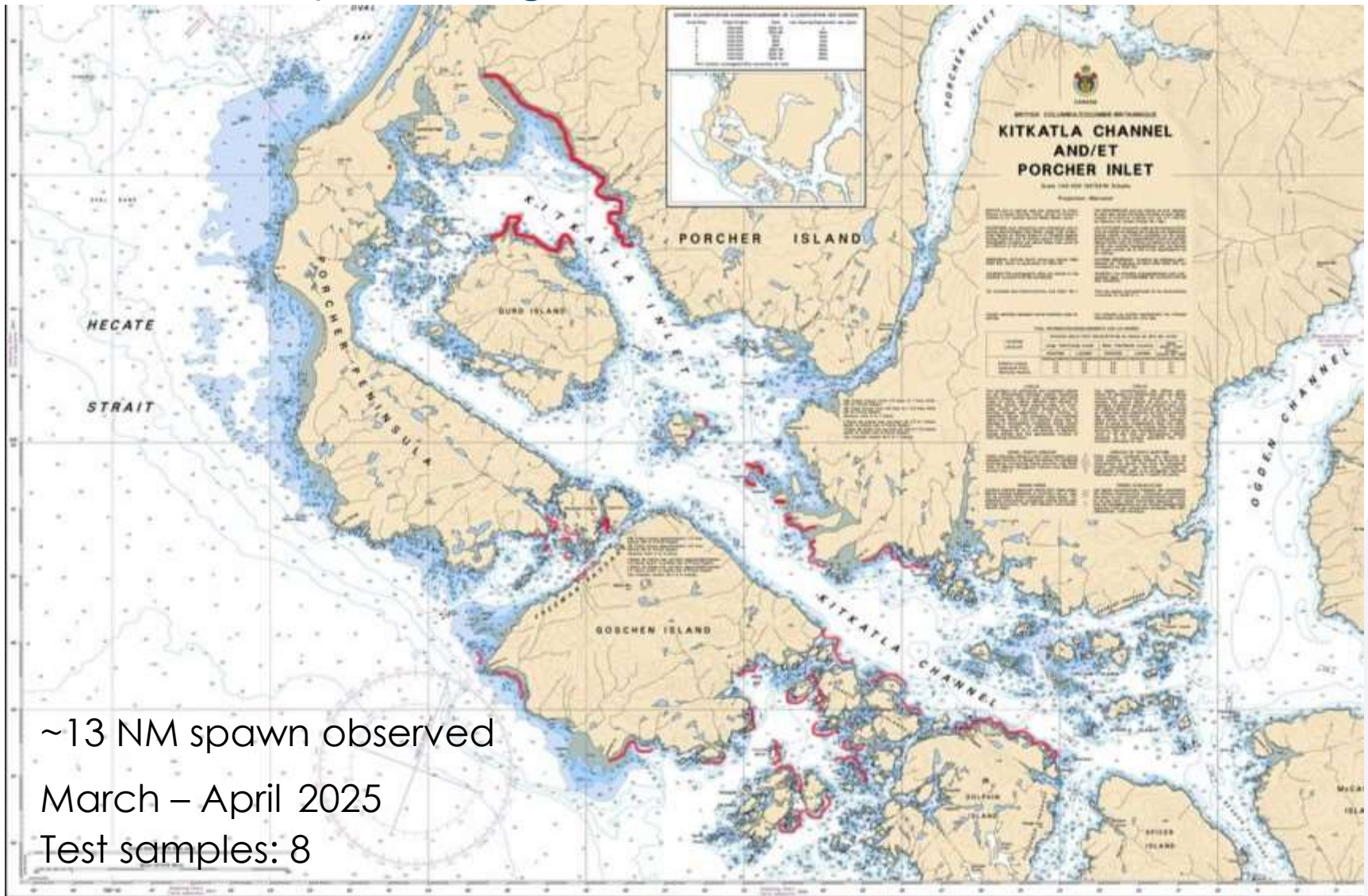
12.82 NM spawn activity observed

Charter Vessel - Nita Maria - Test samples (#) 11

Area 5 – Kitkatla Notes

- First active spawn reported by Gitxaala March 13 'further south than ever before'
 - Mar 14 spawn around community docks, Mar 15 Willis Bay
 - 3000t of fish sounded on charters first day, all in inlet
 - Overall multiple spawns with varied timing; later-timed predominantly spot spawns
- 8 successful samples
 - Scale for calculating fish and roe weight broke during set 2
- Preliminary ~13NM total spawn with ~7000t of fish sounded
- Dive charter indicated another excellent year: thick layers with good coverage, shorter transects

PFMA 5 - Spawn Flight/Charter Vessel Observations

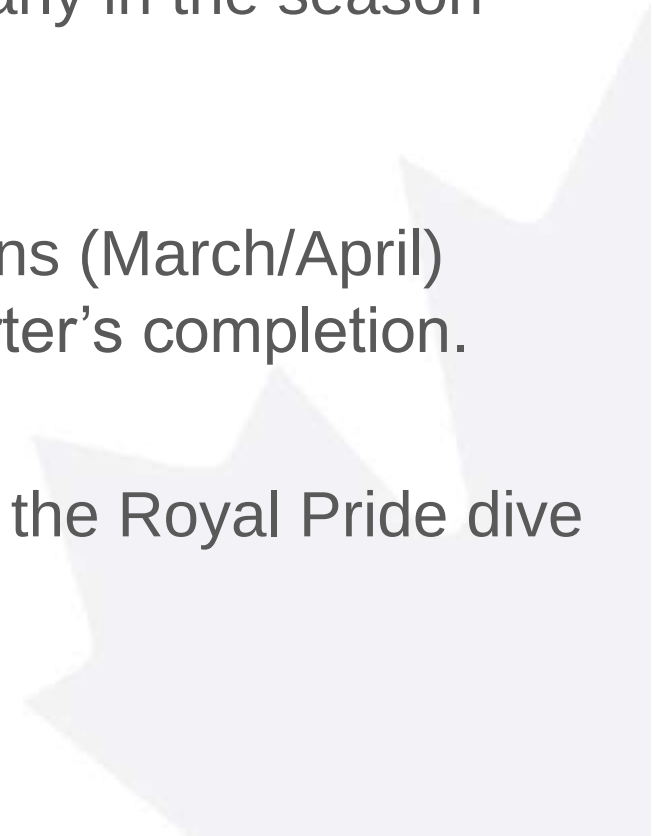


Mar 17 Shakes-Willis-Prager-Dolphin-Shibasha Spawns 2025-03-17 00:00 - 2025-03-17 23:59, Sentinel-2 L2A, True color



Satellite imagery from March 17 of Willis Bay – Dolphin Island spawn

Discussion – Area 4

- Separating the first Nation patrols to cover early and later timing spawn.
 - Metlakatla completed 5 inspections early in the season prior to the start of the DFO charter.
 - Lax kw'alaams completed 5 Inspections (March/April) later in the season after the DFO charter's completion.
 - These inspections assisted in guiding the Royal Pride dive survey throughout the season.
- 

Discussion – Area 5

- On-grounds communication challenges between test vessel and Gitxaala Fisheries staff to complement monitoring
- Lateness of industry confirmation for intent to harvest
- Stakeholder displeasure with field availability of DFO staff
- Second consecutive year of historical 2-part spawn (early and late), more occurring within the inlet
- Earliest recorded spawn: everyone taken by surprise
 - Royal Pride pleased with timing of dive charter to capture both the earlier and the later timed spawns

Questions and Discussion



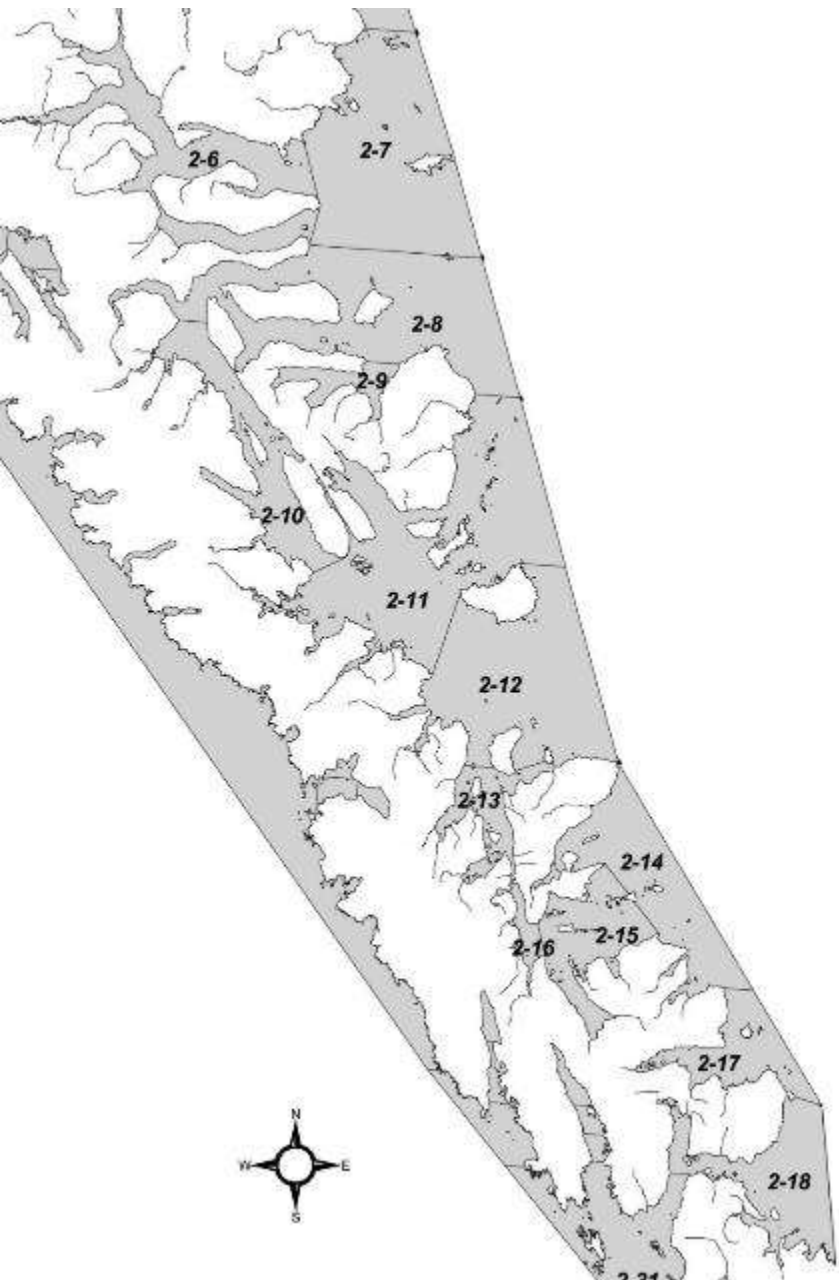


Haida Gwaii

Resource Manager:
Patrick Fairweather



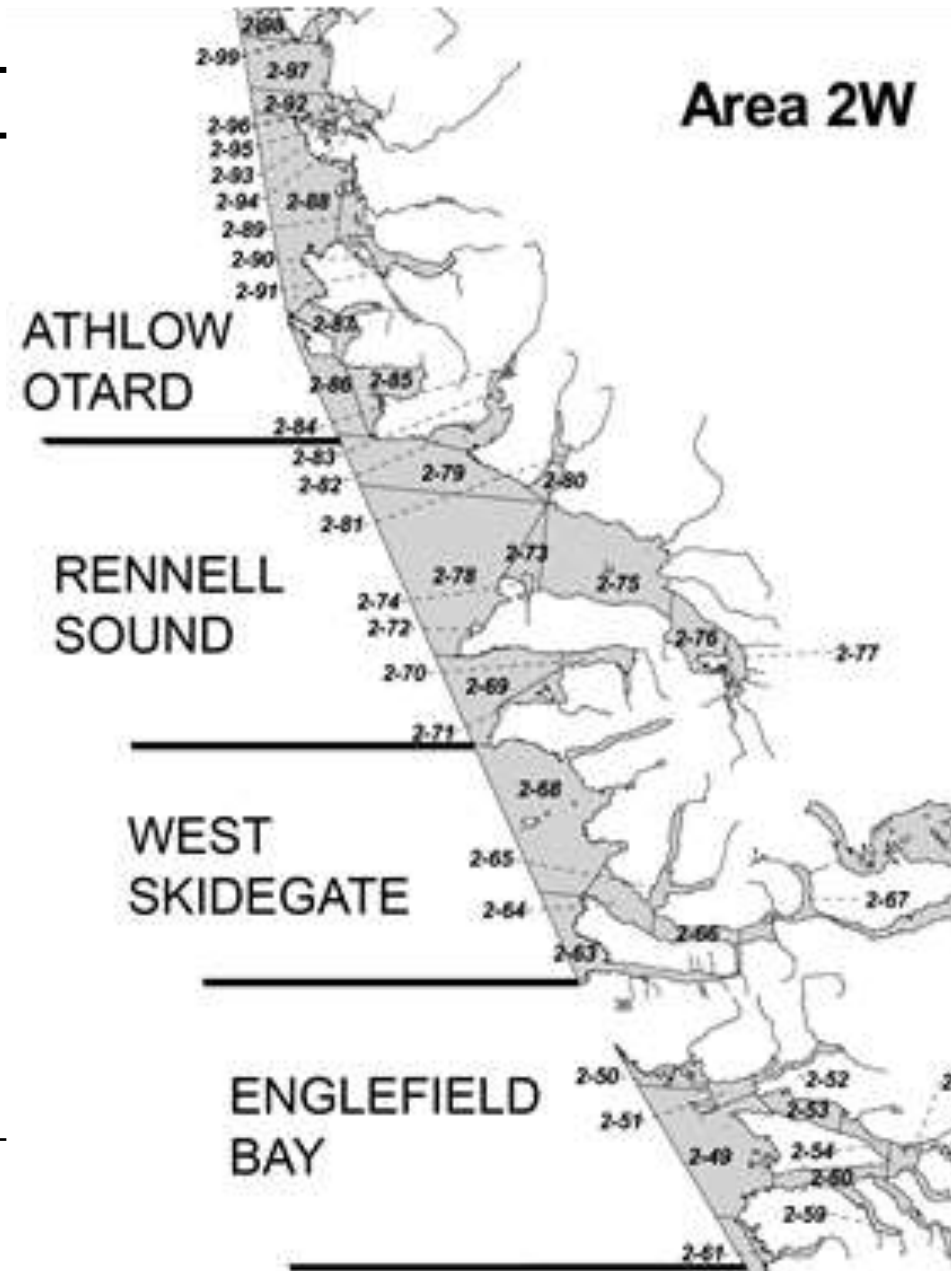
Major Stock Assessment Area (2E)



Location	Soundings	Spawn
Cumshewa	—	1.9 NM (3.5 Km)
Selwyn	950 t	2.9 NM (5.4 Km)
Atli	550 t	1.2 NM (2.2 Km)
Juan Perez	200 t	8.1 NM (15.0 Km)
Burnaby	8,000 t	15.5 NM (28.7 Km)
Skincuttle	950 t	9.0 NM (16.6 Km)
Louscoone (2W)	500 t	1.0 NM (1.8 Km)
TOTAL:		11,150 t 39.6 NM (73.2 Km)

Minor Stock Assessment Area (2W)

Location	Soundings	Length
Port Louis/ Otard Bay	300 t	4.5 NM (8.3 km)
Port Chanal	75 t	None observed
Nesto	NFF	None observed
Seal / Tartu Rennell	500 t	None observed
Kano Inlet	1,200 t	None observed
West Skidegate	400 t	None observed
Englefield Bay	1,200 t	UNK
TOTAL:	3,675 t	4.5 NM (8.3 km)



Harvest Level Decision Context - HG

- Spawning biomass projected to be 8,329 tons (range: 3,677 – 20,355 tons) and below the LRP with a 38% probability in the absence of fishing.
- No commercial harvest opportunities for 2025 in either the major or minor assessment areas, consistent with the Haida Gwaii Herring Rebuilding plan.

2025 Stock Assessment Resources

- Roe Test Seine - Queens Reach: **23-day survey**
(March 12 – April 3)
- Spawn Reconnaissance – Haida Guardian I: **19-day survey**
(March 29 - April 16)
- Dive Survey- Haida Spirit: **16-day survey**
(April 4 – 19)
- 2W Surface Survey – Queens Reach: **6-day survey**
(April 5 – 10)



Queens Reach
Sounding and Test Setting

Haida Spirit
Dive Survey Platform



Haida Gwaii - Stocks and Spawn

Soundings/ Test sets:

- Major Stock Area = 11,150 tons (8 samples)
- Minor Stock Area 2W = 3,675 tons (2 samples)

Observed Spawns:

- Major Stock Area
 - Mar 12 - Apr 11
 - 39.6 NM (73.2 km)
- Minor Stock Area (2W)
 - March 13 – unk.
 - 4.5 NM (8.3 km)



Cumshewa Inlet

Spawn: March 25th,

Length: 1.9 NM (3.5 km)



Selwyn Inlet (1 sample)

Spawn: April 8th and 9th ,

Length: 2.9 NM (5.4 km)



Atli Inlet (1 sample)

Spawn: April 11th, Length: 1.2 NM (2.2 km)



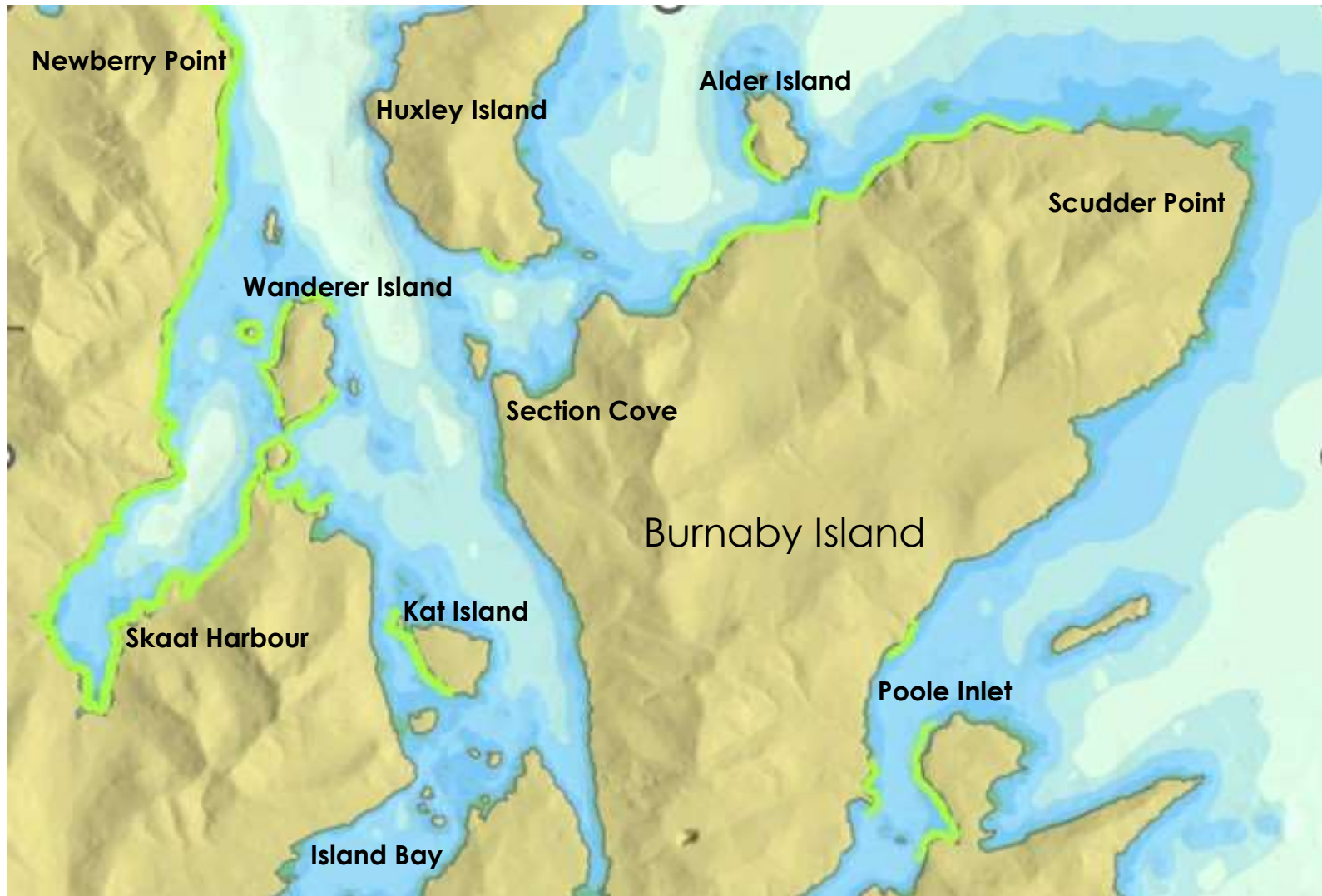
Juan Perez Sound

Spawn: April 3rd, Length: 8.1 NM (15.0 km)



Upper Burnaby Area (5 samples)

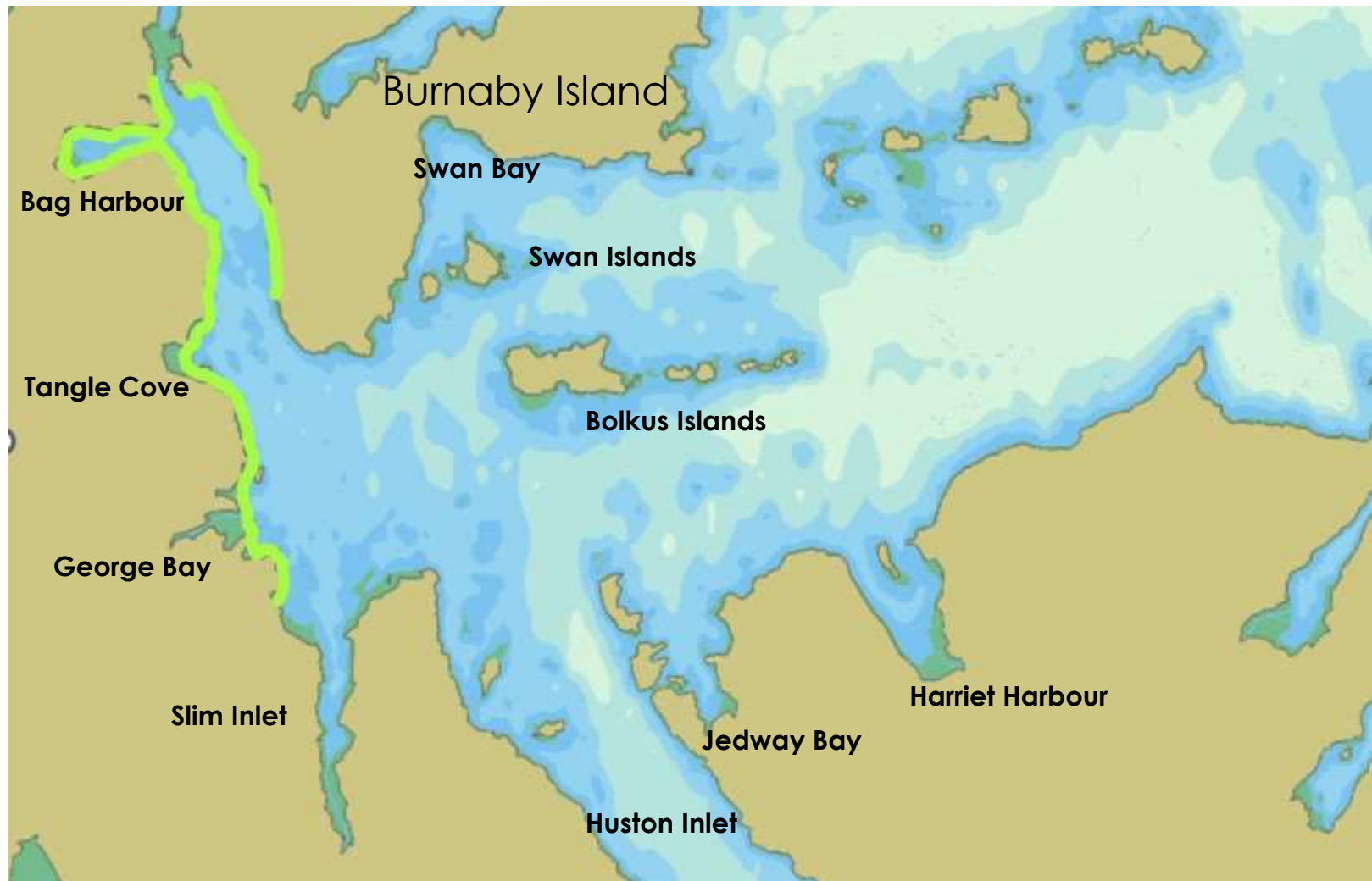
Spawn: March 31st – April 4th, Length: 15.5 NM / (28.7 km)



Skincuttle Area (1 sample)

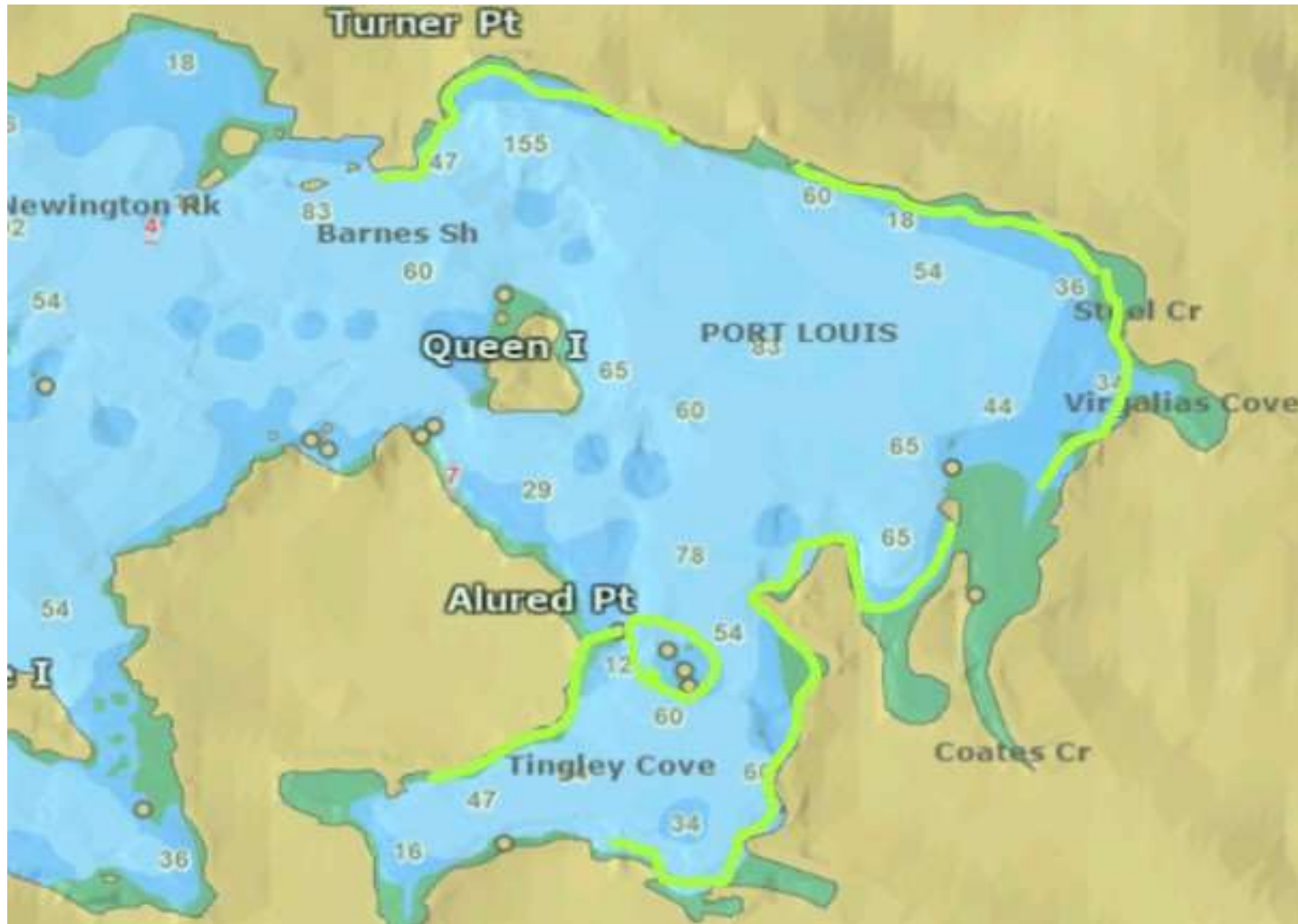
Spawn: March 29th –April 3rd,

Length: 9.0 NM / (16.6 km)



Port Louis (2W)

Spawn: March 13th – 15th , Length: 4.5 NM (8.3 km)



Fishery Landings Breakdown

- A rebuilding plan for Haida Gwaii herring was approved in 2024. As part of the precautionary approach, both the Haida Gwaii major and minor (2W) stock assessment areas were closed to commercial harvest in 2025.
- Approximately 11,000 pounds (preliminary estimate) of FSC spawn on kelp (K'aaw) was harvested in the major stock assessment area in 2025 (as reported by Haida Fisheries Program).

Harvest of k'aaw from suspended lines of kelp

Harvest of wild k'aaw



Area Notes

- Spawn timing in the major stock area was later than the previous year but similar to the average for recent years prior to 2024. Spawn timing in the minor stock area (2W) started somewhat earlier than recent years but also ranged widely from March 13th (north) to at least April 10th (south).
- The main herring aggregations occurred in the Upper Burnaby area and observations suggested that a large proportion moved south through the narrows to spawn in Inner Skincuttle. Spawning also occurred in Matheson and Marshall Inlets (Juan Perez Sound), which has not occurred for several years.
- As in recent years numerous (> 25) Humpback whales were observed in the major stock area and several pods of Orcas were also noted but fewer sea lions were seen.

Discussion - Successes

- All major assessment area spawns were located and dive assessments were completed for the majority. Surface surveys were completed on some smaller spawns in Cumsheewa, Selwyn, Atli and Poole Inlets.
- Despite much earlier timing of spawning in Port Louis Queens Reach was still able to complete a surface survey during the initial sounding test setting trip.
- Haawa! and many thanks to the on grounds survey personnel including the skippers and crews of the Queens Reach, Haida Guardian and Haida Spirit as well as the Haida Fisheries Program dive team.

Discussion – Challenges and Lessons Learned

- Once again in 2025 the abundance of Humpback whales in the Burnaby Strait area (>25) hampered test setting efforts.
 - Area 2W survey timing and coverage continues to be a challenge. Spawn timing in Area 2W ranged from March 13th (Port Louis) to April 10th (Englefield). Since the test vessel did not assess Port Louis until March 20th sample collection was not possible but a surface spawn assessment was completed at that time. Samples were also collected in Seal Inlet and Englefield Bay.
-

Questions and Discussion



Upcoming Engagement

- Transition of PRD area to the updated model framework.
 - Will be the focus of the science work occurring this summer.
- 2025 Assessment Data Summaries:
 - Expected to be released June/July
- Fall Pre-season Meeting:
 - 2025 Stock Assessment and 2026 Forecasts expected late September
 - Tier 2, IHHPC meeting planned for late September or early October 2025. (Dates TBD)

WRAP UP